

Phil 210 Ancient Philosophy

Numbered Transcript

PHIL 210 • Dr. James Orr

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Lecture 1: The Ionian School

At a glance — Orr on the Ionian School.

- 1.1 Welcome to Ancient Philosophy: An Introduction to Greco-Roman Philosophy. In these six lectures, we're going to be walking down some ancient pathways to recover some perennial answers to perennial questions that affect us every day. So I want you to come with me back to the archaic age of ancient Greece. The archaic age is roughly that period between the beginning of the seventh century and the dawn of the classical period at the beginning of the fifth. Let's say about 700 BC, 750 BC, up to 500 BC.
- 1.2 We're going to be looking at Greek-speaking thinkers. But to say that these thinkers are Greek might confuse us a little bit. We're going to be thinking primarily about figures who emerge not in Greece as we know it today, but in that vast sweep of the Mediterranean that was Greek-speaking in the archaic period. We'll be looking in this first lecture at the Ionian school. Ionia is a geographic region. If you think of a mental map of modern-day Turkey, it's the central region of the Anatolian coastline that included, most famously, the city of Miletus, where a lot of our figures were based.
- 1.3 And in the next lecture, we'll be turning to the so-called Eleatic school. Elea is in modern-day Campania, in round about the shin of the Italian boot. So neither place is really Greek in the sense that we understand it today. But it was Greek-speaking. It was culturally Greek. Both of those regions were culturally Greek. Miletus itself, in Ionia, was a place of commerce and trade. The thing about trade is that it's one of the great stimulants for thought. Ideas travel with trade. And so, in Ionia, in the seventh and sixth centuries, you have an extraordinary confluence of ideas and cultures— Egyptian ideas, Phoenician ideas, Babylonian ideas, ideas about mathematics, ideas about religion and the divine, ideas about human beings and our place within the cosmos.
- 1.4 And contrast is the mother of clarity. This was a place in which lots of different ideas were knocking into each other. Lots of different outlooks, lots of different frameworks for thinking started to clash into each other. And it became possible and tempting, as is often the case in cities and regions in which this is happening, it became possible to work out what was common and what was different about these various frameworks. It became possible to think, what is it that these systems have in common? What is it that they don't have in common? It was a way, a place in which common assumptions about the world, forged by religion and tradition, and particular settled political approaches, began to be disturbed. People started to think; it was a cauldron for profound reflection.
- 1.5 Now, I'm going to refer regularly in this lecture and the next lecture to the Ionian school and to the Eleatic school. This distinction is a little artificial. So there'll be some thinkers I will mention in this lecture who don't strictly belong to Ionia. And I'll be speaking in the next lecture about thinkers who were not actually based in that part of

Italy. This is often the case. When we're thinking about philosophy, and particularly the history of philosophy, we need labels.

- 1.6 In contemporary philosophy, there's often a distinction drawn between the Anglo-American tradition and the continental tradition. But once you look under the hood, as you say in America, or you look under the bonnet, you start to see that that doesn't really work. Frege and Wittgenstein were founding fathers of the Anglo-American tradition, and the continental tradition today boasts many American champions and advocates and exponents. But it's just a convenient schema that we'll work with as we go.
- 1.7 One of the great things about going back to the beginning of Western thought is that we start to strip philosophy down to its basic elements. We start to think philosophically about philosophy, to think about thinking. This is a powerful way to get a grip on the extraordinary simplicity of philosophy. It's tempting to think about philosophy as almost a paradigm of complexity and obscurity, something that we can't really—we'd have to wait till university to really get to grips with. But in fact, if philosophy is difficult at all, it is because it raises the most simple questions. This is why children are often the best philosophers. They're always asking, "Why? But why, Daddy? But why?" And that posture of interrogation, of skepticism, is a philosophical posture that is really emerging for the first time, certainly in the West, in this period.
- 1.8 What is it that sets apart these thinkers from those who had gone before? We find in Homer, one of the greatest literary geniuses, if not the greatest literary genius, that the world has ever produced. He was not stupid. He, or the tradition, the oral tradition that we attach the label Homer to, was clearly a profoundly, presented a profoundly sophisticated understanding of human beings, the nature of the world. We see, too, in a figure like Hesiod, who comes a little bit after Homer, an equal genius. Not an equal genius, perhaps, but a genius that is comparable. You can understand, you can see the fingerprints of Homer on a lot of Hesiod's work.
- 1.9 But what's different about what comes in their wake with the Ionian school and later the Eliatic school is a difference of posture. A different set of questions are in the air. What characterizes Homer and Hesiod is an awareness of their finitude. The opening of Homer's Iliad is, "Menin aeide, mousa. Wrath, sing to me, muse." The opening of the Odyssey is, "Andra moi ennepe, mousa. Sing, man, to me, sing, muse." Both of those foundational texts appeal for inspiration to the Muses. They are dependent, if you like, on the divine, for knowledge of the world, for knowledge and for inspiration. It's a fundamentally mystical starting point. Or in the Greek word, we might say, mythos. There's an emphasis on story.
- 1.10 And what we see emerging in the seventh and sixth centuries is logos. This is a typical distinction that scholars will often use, this distinction between mythos and logos. Both words are untranslatable, and if you look them up in an ancient Greek dictionary, you'll see that the definitions run for pages and pages and pages. I don't want to make too

much of this distinction. Again, because mythos and mythology can imply a kind of irrationality, an instability, something fanciful and frivolous. And that's emphatically not what Homer is.

- 1.11** And in the word logos, we have an almost limitless variety of definitions. Logos can mean, it can mean reason, it can mean account, it can mean speech, it can mean thought. But what characterizes these early Greek philosophers, is a stress on interrogating the world to give an account of itself, a logos of itself, through the application of our own capacity to wield logos, our own capacity to grasp the world through reason. It's not simply reason, it's sense experience as well. In fact, one of the big debates will be, how much can we rely on sense experience to reason about the world? Or how much should we be skeptical of what our senses deliver to us? To what extent should we really just rely on armchair thinking, a priori thinking? To what extent can we rely on the senses and perception?
- 1.12** So the two engine rooms of philosophy are here in this framing. The logos of reality and the logos of mind. The nature of ultimate reality and our capacity to track what reality is. In contemporary philosophy-speak, that is the distinction between metaphysics and epistemology. By metaphysics, shorthand definition, metaphysics is the inquiry into the fundamental building blocks of reality. It might be that the fundamental building blocks of ultimate reality are physical building blocks. That's what a lot of philosophers and scientists and everyday people would insist today, that ultimate reality is physical reality.
- 1.13** But that is not itself a finding of physics. That is a metaphysical claim. It's a claim about the nature of ultimate reality. Physics itself can't tell us anything about what's not physics. Biology can't tell us anything about what's not biology. That's not a limitation of physics and biology. It's simply an observation of the proper parameters of those disciplines, of those avenues of human inquiry. To ask the question, "Is it physics all the way down?", is not to ask a physical question, a question in physics. It's not a question that could be established through physics. If there is more to reality than simply physics, physics couldn't tell us. Physics must remain agnostic. That's metaphysics.
- 1.14** The second engine room, epistemology. Another Greek word, from episteme, meaning knowledge, and logos, the study. There's that logos word again, the study, the account of knowledge. Again, here we're shifting from the nature of ultimate reality to, well, whatever reality actually is, how could we find out anything about it? In many ways, that's a more astonishing thought. It's an astonishing presupposition of the philosopher, or of any of us, that we have within us, little old us, finite, fragile, fallen, if you're a Christian, somehow we have the capacity to work out what the nature of ultimate reality is. How is that possible? And how would we go about justifying what it is that our cognitive capacities and our perceptual capacities pick out in the world? And this is both of these, as I said, the engine rooms. These will be golden threads running through our sessions together.

- 1.15** Notice that, at this point, we've not started to talk very much about who we are as human beings, what we ought to do. That is to say, we're not talking about anthropology, the philosophy of human nature, nor are we talking about ethics. We are, as it were, in a pre-humanist framework here. That's going to come later. That's going to come with the dawn of the classical era and the figure of Socrates. Socrates, one of only two philosophers in the history of Western philosophy to whom we can legitimately attach the prefix pre and post. Socrates has such an impact on Western philosophy that it is to some extent legitimate to talk about the pre-Socratics and the post-Socratics. The other philosopher is Immanuel Kant. That's for another lecture series.
- 1.16** Now, you might say, well, why are we spending two sessions on a whole load of philosophers who are labeled in the textbooks by the word pre-Socratics? They are the pre-Socratics, or Nietzsche said, the pre-Platonics. They just came before the real thing. Well, Nietzsche himself and Martin Heidegger, two terrifying, colossal figures in the history of modern philosophy, thought that not only is it not true that philosophy begins once these guys end, but that, in fact, philosophy ends with this chapter, this early chapter. For Nietzsche and for Heidegger, the arrival of Socrates and Plato on the scene is a disaster. It ends our natural inquiry into the mystery of the meaning of being, says Heidegger.
- 1.17** That's one reason we're going to spend some time on these figures because, to some extent, they're right to see these figures, in Nietzsche's words, as the archetypes of philosophical thought. "All posterity," he writes in a very early treatise, *Philosophy in the [Tragic] Age of the [Greeks]*, "all posterity has not made an essential contribution to the Greek philosophers since. [...] They are devoid of conventionality, these thinkers. For in their day, there were no philosophers, there were no academics," there were no people like me, in other words. In that period, they were unfettered by the claims of society, and they were unfettered by the category of philosopher.
- 1.18** One feature characterizes these different thinkers for all their differences, and that is a fundamental intuition, not shared in the Homeric tradition, not shared by Hesiod, not shared by many of those figures whose thought we're able to reconstruct running up to the seventh and sixth century. And that is the intuition that the world is ordered. The world is an orderly place. It's patterned, it's regular. There are features that we can explore, and there are features that we can understand. There isn't a sharp break from the view that reality is to be understood in some mystical religious way, to the view that everything is to be understood in purely rational terms. Again, that's an artificial modern distinction that's probably unhelpful. We'll see that theme recurring again and again.
- 1.19** A lot of these philosophers are profoundly mystical. Some of them express themselves in poetry, sometimes using the very meter, the dactylic hexameter, of Homer and Hesiod themselves. Some of the philosophers, I'm thinking here of Pythagoras, was

basically a cult leader. He was a leader of a religious, something like a religious movement. Many of these philosophers would be baffled, astonished, at the idea that the philosophical positions you signed up to could not have a fundamental impact on the way you lived your life— what you ate, how you dressed, whether you had a beard, what kind of a beard you had if you had one. Plato had a very neat long beard. Diogenes the Cynic had a disgusting beard, and that was part of the point. It was a way of signaling to society his rejection of society.

- 1.20** So philosophy is a little, is to be understood a little bit like we would understand a religion today. That's got an intuitive appeal. Why would you not live out the beliefs that you hold? If you really believed in the transmigration of souls, that is to say that a soul would, on the death of one biological organism, transmit itself to another biological organism, why would that not affect your views about vegetarianism? Vegetarianism will seem rather attractive if your ribeye steak might have been Grandma. It seems obvious. So we need to get away from this distinction that we have in our minds between philosophy and religion. They're just, they're fused. That distinction would have been unintelligible to these figures.
- 1.21** Philosophy infuses all thought for them, as it does for us. Even today in the modern university, or the modern multiversity, we're all researching our different things, different topics. One of the, possibly the only discipline that could claim to unite all of these is philosophy. Why? Because of this fundamental approach, this fundamental layer to how it approaches questions. So there's a philosophy of religion. There's a philosophy of mathematics, there's a philosophy of biology, there's a philosophy of language, there's a philosophy of politics, political philosophy, of course. All of those are possible, not just possible, but important. Because philosophy gets at the deepest questions that it's possible to ask, gets at the deepest presuppositions that it's possible to get to.
- 1.22** And that's why it's so important, if we're to avoid the kind of dialogue of the deaf that so deafens and so characterizes the public square today, it's important for us to understand where these different frameworks come from, what's operating at the deepest levels, even if it's just to sort out the nature of a disagreement. A lot of these disagreements will spring not from settled philosophical arguments, but from very often pre-rational intuitions, pre-rational instinctive takes on the world, which we will then dress up in arguments very often. But it's important, at least, to be able to uncover those, to uncover what are assumptions, bedrock assumptions, and which are not, which we might argue over.
- 1.23** We're also not going to talk in these early lectures about political community and justice. These are questions that emerge really in the fifth century, with Plato, with Socrates, with the Sophistic tradition. The so-called pre-Socratics are not really interested, at least what we have of them, what's come down to us from them, suggests a primary focus on M and E, on metaphysics and epistemology. So let's dive in.

Who are we going to start with? Who is our first thinker? Well, let's begin where most of the textbooks begin, and that is with the figure of Thales, T-H-A-L-E-S. Thales of Miletus. He's from Miletus. And as with almost all of the pre-Socratics, in fact, every single one, what remains of Thales are frustrating fragments, frustratingly brief fragments, which we then have to piece together.

- 1.24** This, by the way, is what makes ancient philosophy so much fun. It's the same as what makes ancient history so much fun. The material that you've got has been shattered by history. It's been shattered by the fragility. The fragility of history means that very little of what they wrote has come down to us. And so the task of the ancient philosopher, the task of the ancient historian, is to try and piece everything together and reconstruct. And that requires profound insight and understanding of the cultures from which they came. If you compare that to today, we have the contemporary philosopher and the contemporary historian is just, is drowning in resources and has to navigate his way through all the different resources and try and pick a way through. It's very different when we're looking at these figures.
- 1.25** It's difficult to date these figures, but in the case of Thales, we've got a pretty plausible story that he predicted a solar eclipse correctly, and there's not much reason to dispute this. And that solar eclipse occurred on the 28th of May, 585 BC. So that doesn't give us his birth date, it doesn't give us his death date, but it does give us what's often referred to in the textbooks as his "floruit." His floruit. Floruit is a Latin word meaning flourished or peaked. Roughly, we might not know when they were born, might not know when they died, but that's the point where there's a kind of peak of their lifetime or careers. So that 585 gives us a fairly good indication that Thales is around in the first half of the sixth century BC.
- 1.26** What else do we know about him? Well, there's an ancient source that says that, while doing astronomy and looking up into the sky, Thales fell into a well, and that a witty and charming Thracian handmaiden made fun of him, saying that he was eager to know what was in the sky, but didn't see what was in front of him and at his feet. And this is a very common view of philosophers ever since. It's in fact how Raphael, in the great painting, the School of Athens, that's how he describes, how he paints Plato, looking up, up into the sky. What else do we know about him? Well, Aristotle describes him as a physiologos, physiologos. Somebody who worried about giving an account, a logos, of "Physis." Physis is another of those difficult Greek words, easiest to translate simply as nature. Nature.
- 1.27** Another of the great pairs of concepts that we'll be looking at in our lectures will be between Physis, nature, and nomos, convention, law, norm. We'll see that this characterizes an awful lot of Greek thought, this tension between nature out there and the world of the city state, the world of the polis, the world of human beings, the world of laws, human laws. So he's a physiologos. That suggests he's interested in nature, what Physis is. And one of his fragments—this is Aristotle. "Houtos," this man, "Houtos

epe archen tou pantos einai kai telos to hudor." This man said that the founding principle, the arche, tou pantos, of everything, and its final end, its telos, its purpose, was, einai, wait for it. Water. Water is the fundamental ingredient in all reality.

- 1.28** This is Nietzsche again. "Is it really necessary for us to take seriously this kind of proposition?" Is this really where, is this the great moment at which the dawn of thought emerges? Really? Water. He goes on. "Yes. And for three reasons. First, because it tells us something about the primal origins of things." Or he's trying to get to the primal origins of things. This is progress. OK, may not be water, but he's got to "arche", he's got to this notion there's something that's a fundamental principle, the start of all things.
- 1.29** Second, because Thales does this in language that's devoid of image or fable. And third, because contained in it, if only embryonically, is the thought all things are one. So that first idea, there's a, this idea that all things, the fundamental principle is water. This statement, whatever we think of whether it's right or not, just this statement, this claim, is one that is attempting to get to the ultimate nature of reality, and in that sense has a kind of religious sensibility. It's how you might characterize the opening pages of Genesis or the opening verses of John's Gospel. It's a philosophical creation account. This is what everything comes from.
- 1.30** But second, it also, says Nietzsche, puts Thales in the company of the natural scientists. This is a claim about stuff that you can see, in principle, analyze, run experiments on. A claim that you can test hypothetically through experimentation. And third, says Nietzsche, this is what makes him the first Greek philosopher. It's a claim about all reality. It's a claim about ultimate reality. And I think it's a brilliant way of characterizing it because it shows how he, Thales, marks this transition from a mystical, religious thought-world through to a world in which we can ask scientific questions about the nature of things and meta-scientific questions, meta-physical questions, about whether what we are finding in the sciences is in fact all things. All reality.
- 1.31** What characterizes the Ionian school, sometimes the Milesian school, those figures emerging from Miletus and the towns around it, is a materialist outlook. So the idea is that the kinds of answers that need to be generated, that they're reaching, are answers or candidates for the nature of ultimate reality that is stuff. In this case, it's water, it's matter, something that's material. The great thinker who follows Thales is Anaximander. Anaximander. Now, there are at least three. There's Anaximander, there's Anaximenes, and Anaxagoras, thinkers who begin with those four letters, Anax. Anax, in Homeric Greek, means Lord. Anax Achilles, Lord Achilles. Anax Agamemnon, Lord Agamemnon. It's one of those names that those terms have lodged themselves in these seventh, sixth century BC names.
- 1.32** Anaximander comes very shortly after Thales, we think. And what marks him as a thinker is not so much an inquiry into the nature of ultimate reality that can yield some kind of thing, some kind of stuff. What impresses him is a distinction that has really

been with us ever since in philosophy. And that's a question between what's determinate, finite, fixed, and what is indeterminate, infinite. The notion of the infinite begins with Anaximander. And his reasoning goes something like this. What ultimately exists, what is ultimately real, can't be something that has definite characteristics. It can't be like any other kind of thing that comes to be and passes away. If we're looking for that on which everything else depends, it can't be just some kind of thing. It can't draw on characteristics that populate the world that it is sustaining and explaining.

1.33 If it was the color blue, we could then say, why not red? It has to be, says Anaximander, something indeterminate, something that hasn't got any characteristics at all, including any characteristics that might delimit it or characterize it in some way. It must be indeterminate, non-finite, infinite, "to apeiron, to apeiron." And this is what makes it a plausible candidate, says, for Anaximander. This indeterminate, infinite source of being isn't vulnerable to death. It's not vulnerable to erosion. It's something that is primal. It's something that exists, no matter what. It's everlasting. It's, as it were, immortal. It's not determinate.

1.34 Now, notice that this is another distinction. This is a claim that you can't establish through sense experience. It's not something you could detect. By definition, if you could detect it, it would have characteristics. If it had characteristics, it'd be determinate. It'd be a particular thing. And so, what that means is that Anaximander is using reason alone. He's saying, "What is helping me to detect this ultimate principle is not my senses. It's not what I can hear. It's not what I can touch. It's not what I can smell. It's what I can think. It's what I'm reasoning my way here."

1.35 Now, again, it's hard to overstate what a revolution this is in the history of thought. Anaximander is saying we can just pull back, shut our eyes, and reason about the ultimate nature of reality. That's an extraordinary moment in the history of philosophy. In many ways, it marks the beginning of Western philosophy. Other figures follow. Anaximenes. Anaximenes said, "No, Thales is almost right, but I think it's air, not hydor, it's not water. Ultimate reality, all things are really reducible just to air."

1.36 We might laugh at that, or we might not. Part of what impresses Anaximenes is our own dependence on air. The extraordinary creatures that we are, one thing we know we need is air. Take that away, that's the one thing which, when you take it away, we're going to die very quickly. Water, I mean, we've got three days. Air, we really need air. Air is, to them, anyway, would have seemed non-material. You need it, but you can't see it. It can exist in different modes as well. If we depend for our existence on air, why not advance as a candidate for that on which all things depend? Air. All life depends on air. Look up into the heavens, it's air. You see the air, you see through it. The "arche", the fundamental principle, says Anaximenes, is air.

1.37 Now, again, we can worry about whether this is, in fact, philosophy. It seems like science. It's what we might think of today as a very primitive form of science. But it's trying to be philosophy, too. It's making claims that this candidate, that you could

actually inspect it through science, is somehow that in virtue of which all reality is, is what it is. That is the Milesian school. These are the great Milesian thinkers.

- 1.38** Not far away from Miletus is the town of Ephesus. Ephesus, probably most famous from being the site of one of the seven wonders of the ancient world, the great Artemisium, the great temple to Artemis at Ephesus. You can still see it if you go to modern-day Turkey. Also, very plausibly, the location of the Johannine community, very plausibly the location near where St. John wrote the fourth Gospel, and where, it's from that community that it's thought that the three other New Testament texts, 1 John, 2 John, 3 John, emerged. Ephesus, in this period, like Miletus, is a hub of commercial and cultural activity, a nerve center for all the different ideas that are swirling around the Eastern half of the Mediterranean world.
- 1.39** And there's an appropriate parallel, you might say, in that Ephesus is the birthplace of the great thinker, Heraclitus, for whom the notion of logos is crucial. There's a great parallel there because, of course, it's invoking logos, reason, the principle of order in all things that John appeals to at the beginning of the fourth Gospel. *En arche en ho logos*. In the beginning. There's that "arche" word, that fundamental principle, in the beginning, in the originating source of all things, *en ho logos*, was the logos.
- 1.40** That's 600 years later. But in round about 500 BC, there emerges this figure, Heraclitus of Ephesus, who also engages profoundly in this question of the logos. Nothing is permanent, says Heraclitus. But there is beneath everything logos, reason, rationality, intelligibility. And there's a tension here in Heraclitus' thought. He is, on the one hand, the philosopher of change and flux and chaos, and dynamism. And yet, beneath it, he will insist that there is an organizing principle, an organizing law, the logos. And because what we have of his writings is so fragmentary, it's hard. It's easy for us to say, "Oh, he was just incoherent and contradictory." And it is easy to be unfair to him.
- 1.41** One way you could reconcile this apparent, this contradiction, one way you could resolve it, would be to say that it may be a distinction operating at the level of sense experience. When we experience the world, we see that it's a world of change, of coming and going, of motion, of becoming. But when we reason about things, paradigmatically, when we reason about mathematics, we are, as it were, almost getting underneath the skin of becoming and of change and of dynamism to something steady and pure, something that exists no matter what. We'll come back to that thought later on with the figure of Pythagoras, but I wanted to just float it there so that it's on your radar, this distinction between the messiness of sense experience and the purity of thought.
- 1.42** The rationalist tradition in Western philosophy. This is a crude distinction, but still plausible. The rationalist tradition in Western philosophy, from Plato to Descartes and Leibniz and Spinoza, are enormously impressed with the purity of thought in contrast to the messiness of sense experience. The empiricist tradition in Western philosophy, let's say, Aristotle and John Locke, and George Berkeley, and David Hume, are

suspicious of reason, think that reason can get us all muddled. If we reason too much, we'll end up falling into wells. Surely what you see is what you get. Well, that's what you should start with. You could see it. Isn't that the outlook of scientific inquiry? And look at the great achievements of science over the last 250 years. Who would want to surrender that method of sense experience first? Whatever reason tells us.

- 1.43 This approach laughs at philosophers like me or economists about whom the joke is often told. They're the people who would say, "Well, that works in practice, but does it work in theory?" So another big tension and important polarity, as it were, is reason and experience, rationalism and empiricism. Again, I've sketched it quite crudely there, but just so that it's in your minds. We'll go into some more detail as to why that can be an unhelpful way of framing things. But for now, that is a good distinction that helps us to—that it should be part of the roadmap as we're looking at these different thinkers.
- 1.44 So, Heraclitus. What else did he think? Well, I've talked about the logos, and in a way that's a slightly misleading place to start, because he's typically understood in terms of, as a philosopher who emphasizes flux and change in everything. He is reputed to have said that you can't step into the same river twice. You might have heard that, "ποταμοῖσι τοῖσιν αὐτοῖσιν ἐμβαίνουσιν ἕτερα καὶ ἕτερα ὕδατα ἐπιρρεῖ." That means roughly, to those walking across the same rivers, different waters flow and flow. You can hear it in the language, hopefully. "ποταμοῖσι τοῖσιν αὐτοῖσιν ἐμβαίνουσιν ἕτερα καὶ ἕτερα ὕδατα ἐπιρρεῖ." Again, there's that poetic quality to pre-Socratic expression. This is still the world, the final twilight of the Homeric age.
- 1.45 What does he mean by this? Well, he means what he says. You can't step into the same river twice. Step into the Danube once, the second time it's an entirely different configuration of H₂O molecules around your foot. It's a different foot. Don't the physiologists, don't the biologists tell us that we are ourselves changing at the molecular level the whole time? Every seven years, every seven or eight years? Cratylus, who came after Heraclitus, is reputed to have said, not only can you not step into the same river twice, you can't even step into it once. You can't even name a river. What does it even mean to say that the Danube is the Danube? Before you've finished naming it Danube, it is no longer what it was when you started to utter the letter D.
- 1.46 And Cratylus, who's one of my favorite philosophers, said he refused to say anything. He would point to things occasionally. But he thought that language itself is just no point every time you try and pick something out in the world, it's no longer the same thing as it was when you started the sentence. So silence is the best policy. Silence is the true philosophical stance, he said. Nothing has identity. Not even one thing has identity. Now, this might seem like logic chopping, but in fact, we're probing a deep philosophical question here. If we think we can even get a grip on what reality ultimately is, well, it's got to stay one thing when we're thinking about it. Otherwise, why think about it at all?

- 1.47 And really, it's just an intensification of that conviction that what's real is what we see. And if what we see is plainly changing the whole time, then how can we come up with any stable notion, of any stable way of trying to understand it, or talk about it, or think about it? Heraclitus also is reputed to have said that the road up and the road down are the same, are one and the same. The road up and the road down are one and the same. What might that mean? Well, again, exactly what he said. If you're at the bottom of the hill, looking up, you see the road taking you to the top of the hill. You see your friend at the top of the hill, looking down the road. It's the same road, says Heraclitus. It seems different, difference of perspective, but it's the same road.
- 1.48 Elsewhere, he says, "The sea, thalassa, the purest water and the foulest. For fish, it's drinkable and life-giving. For humans, undrinkable and deadly." We see, in pregnant statements like that, the seeds of relativism, the seeds of perspectivalism, the view that even if we could get to understand what reality is, whatever answer we give is necessarily refracted through us, the inquirer. Even if we're an empiricist, even if we're a rationalist, our reason is our reason, not anybody else's. Our perceptual capacities, our senses are our senses, not any other kind of being's, not anybody else's.
- 1.49 So here we have also the seeds of skepticism. Well, if our different takes on the world are just different, and if we're using a different set of tools, every single person is using a different set of tools, whether they're sensory tools or cognitive tools, how can we agree on anything? Even if we did agree, how would we not know that that agreement is an accident? And the only way out would be to say, possibly that, well, "only my view matters." There are many positions in the history of philosophy that can seem mad. This is probably the maddest of them all, the idea of solipsism. Cicero, and I think Descartes says something similar, says that there is no idea that's so crazy that some philosopher somewhere hasn't tried to defend it. But there are very few solipsists around.
- 1.50 One of the only ones I've come across is a lady, one of the first American women to get a PhD in the States, and she is reputed to have written to Bertrand Russell, saying, "Dear Russell, I have decided to try out solipsism," the view that all reality is what I say that it is, and that all other people are just figments of my imagination. "It is so much fun. I just don't understand why more people don't try it." So the seeds of skepticism emerge with Heraclitus, this troubling thought that differences in perspective can hamper our inquiry after absolute truth. That, again, is going to come back as we go further into the course. With Heraclitus, however, we do have this underlying, this undertow, of logos, as the ordering principle behind all things. And, as it were, the idea that conflict and tension and difference is operating on the surface.
- 1.51 We might ask at this point, where are the gods in all this? Heraclitus, no more than Anaximander, Anaximenes, or Thales, could not be described as atheists. The word atheism, the word atheist, atheism is almost unintelligible as a concept in the ancient world. In fact, it's scarcely intelligible until really the 17th century. Once upon a time,

there was no atheism, and that time was not so very long ago. There were one or two that emerged, but it was seen as a very strange and superstitious way of thinking about the world. It was one of the very few options that were not seriously entertained.

- 1.52** We'll see towards the end of this series with the Epicureans, the followers of Epicurus, something like atheism, but it's much more what we would call deism. It's a commitment to the existence of gods somewhere, but the gods have got a bit bored and they've just gone off and gone to have a cup of tea and start another the world. They're not, they don't not exist. They do exist. You see in Thales, you see in Anaximander, Anaximenes, this notion of the divine or a relaxed attitude towards the notion that whatever is fundamental is somehow also divine. So much so that they're willing to think of even human beings as having a fragment of divinity within them. But that's a good explanation of how it is that we, of all biological organisms, have the capacity to grasp the world, to reason about it.
- 1.53** The fact that we can do that, the fact that we're interested in these questions, is an astonishing fact when one thinks about it. It's a very strange feature of human beings, which itself cries out for philosophical explanation. We'll come on to see how important that is for Plato, and in particular for Aristotle, after him, later in the course. But what we do start to see in the seventh and sixth centuries, with the Ionian school, is the emergence of a kind of skepticism about the way the divine and the religious was understood in the Homeric era. The crude polytheism that characterizes Homer and Hesiod.
- 1.54** And here we have the fascinating figure of Xenophanes of Colophon, who famously suggests that "Horses, oxen, and lions would have horses as gods, oxen as gods, and lions as gods." We divinize what we are. This is an idea that goes all the way through up to the 19th century. There's a famous figure of Ludwig Feuerbach, who insists that all religion is to be explained in terms of our projecting onto a grand divinized supernatural canvas features of ourselves. This theology is anthropology. Religion is a kind of narcissism, species narcissism.
- 1.55** And that critical attitude to religion, that critical attitude to received religious wisdom, characterizes a lot of these figures. But that's not the same as skepticism towards the divine as such. They're very happy to appeal to God, or theos, as existing at some fundamental level, and at some fundamental explanatory level, too. In fact, a lot of the arguments that we see, for example, in somebody like Anaximander bear a resemblance to the sorts of arguments for Abrahamic monotheism that we see in somebody like Leibniz in the Enlightenment. Leibniz argues that there must be some necessarily existing thing upon which all other things are contingent, all other things depend.
- 1.56** We can ask of everything except a necessarily existing being, God, why? Why does it exist? What does it depend upon for its existence? And that's going to take you, says Leibniz, all the way back to something that stands in no need of an explanation, that is

its own explanation for its existence, which, Leibniz insists, is God. The only alternative, says Leibniz, is an infinite regression of explanations that's never going to get us anywhere. It's a vicious circle, a vicious infinity of questions. And there's something like that going in a figure like Anaximander. And in all of these figures, a willingness to associate the divine with what is ultimate, what doesn't depend upon anything else.

1.57 So there is a very quick roller coaster ride through an interesting cast of characters, a very varied cast, figures who don't obviously owe their influence to any of the others. They are, to some extent, they stand on their own merits and don't bear each other's fingerprints. And figures whose ideas may seem a little bit crude and even laughable to us, but understood in the context of what had come before, can be characterized very seriously as the founders of Western philosophy. Thanks for listening.

Lecture 2: The Eleatic School

At a glance — The Eleatic School.

- 2.1 In the opening lecture, we looked at the question of what philosophy is, what human inquiry it is, and we dug deep into its early beginnings in Ionia, the western coast of modern-day Turkey. I want you to come across with me right across the Mediterranean towards Italy, the western coast of Italy, and to a place called Elea. And we'll be talking in this lecture about the Eleatic school. Again, some of the people we'll be discussing probably wouldn't be placed by most contemporary historians within the Eleatic school. But I think we can pick out an Eleatic outlook, if you like. An Eleatic habit of thought, a way of thinking about reality, and the questions that the Ionian school touched on, too.
- 2.2 Remember, with Thales, it was water; with Anaximenes, it was air. With Heraclitus, it was fire. Fire was the great element that captured ultimate reality, captured that sense of flux and dynamism through which Heraclitus understood reality. And you might say that there's something that resembles the natural sciences here. It's an attempt to locate an element that's a scientific element, and then put it right at the fundamental foundational layer of explanation, the "arche".
- 2.3 With the Eleatic school, we have the emergence of a skepticism towards this idea that one single material thing could play this role. In fact, we have a shift from the notion that any of philosophy's deepest questions could be answered by reference to something that is contained in the world of Becoming. Anything that is contained in the world that is in a state of Becoming once did not exist, and once and soon will cease to be, at some point in the future, will cease to exist. What characterizes the Eleatic school is a focus not on Becoming, but on Being. Capital B, Being.
- 2.4 And the crucial figure at the beginning of this chapter goes by the name of Parmenides. Parmenides of Elea. And we're moving at this point now out of the seventh and sixth centuries into the fifth century. We're now in the world of classical Greece. And yet we're also in Italy. We're in Magna Graecia, as it's been called for many centuries, Great Greece, Magna Graecia. It's easy to forget, indeed, many people are not aware of the fact that Italy and Sicily in this period, really from the seventh century onwards, were populated by Greeks who had left their cities in Attica and the Peloponnese; that is what we now understand as mainland Greece.
- 2.5 They'd left their metropolis, their mother cities, their metropolises, and through overpopulation and disease and just the spirit of exploration—you know something about that in America —and had left their city-states, their mother, their metropolis, to set up "thygater polis", daughter cities. Naples in Greece is Napoli, "nea polis", new city. We're off. We're going to explore this faraway land called Italy, and we're going to find a new city, nea polis. We're going to found a city on this amazing island, Sicily. This

huge, perfect harbor. Well, let's just put a city here. Harbor is ormos, pan ormos, harbor for everything. It can fit everything, this harbor. Pan ormos, pan ormos, panormo, Palermo. Palermo, capital of Sicily. And so on and so forth.

- 2.6 Many of these iconic Italian cities were, once upon a time, Greek. Greek colonies. And so, like America in the 17th century, this Magna Graecia, these Greek-speaking colonized parts of the Mediterranean, were places where you could say and do and believe things that you probably couldn't get away with back home. And so there was a spirit of openness, of open inquiry, just as there was in Ionia. There, there was a spirit of open inquiry just because it was, there were just so many cultures rubbing along with each other, and there was a sense of , yeah, a sense of political freedom before the Persians arrived, anyway. But there was, in Magna Graecia and in Elea in particular, a sense of intellectual freedom.
- 2.7 Parmenides is a notoriously difficult philosopher to understand. Even once we think we're in a position to reconstruct his fragments and piece together what he thought, even once we've pieced together what we thought, semi-successfully, he's still difficult to understand. You might say that's a symptom of all philosophical inquiry into the deepest things. Once you go really deep, things do get difficult. And there's very little in philosophy that's harder to elucidate than the word Being. If you are in the Anglo-American so-called analytic tradition of Western philosophy that begins in the late 19th century, early 20th century, this talk of Being is just a mystification. This is something the continental Europeans do. It's something that was done before there was any true grasp of clear thinking.
- 2.8 But Parmenides insists that we start from Being. Why? Because Being, for Parmenides, is something that we can't really be in any doubt about. I mean, surely we can all agree that there are things, and that things are. Your opponent in a debate may not like you very much, but he's at least going to grant you your existence for the debate to be possible. We may laugh at this, but this is an important method in philosophy. Start from what you agree on. Start at least from first principles. Start from principles that are, what could, in principle, could, in theory, be shared by any rational interlocutor. And just start from there.
- 2.9 And Parmenides' strategy is to say, well, look, things are. There are things. Who wants to deny that? To deny it would be to affirm it. No, nothing is, says Parmenides' imaginary critic. There is nothing. Well, there seems to be at least one thing. Imagine we're in the Matrix. Or imagine that we're a brain in a vat being manipulated by clever scientists to think that we're listening to a lecture. Or imagine, as I understand some people in Silicon Valley are suggesting today, that we exist in a simulation. Everything is a simulation. And there's a particular story that the simulation is unfolding in line with. Well, all of those crazy skeptical scenarios require there to be something. A mind that's being deceived. A simulated reality is still reality. It's something.

- 2.10** We might say then that Parmenides' starting point is about as reasonable a starting point as there could be. But what there could be, says Parmenides, is shaped by what we can think about and what we can talk about. His most famous fragment is a piece of a poem, *Peri Phuseos*, about on nature. And it narrates the journey of a young man, a "kouros", who's taken to meet a goddess, and the goddess promises to teach him "ta panta", all things. So far, so Homeric. Remember the beginning of the *Odyssey*, the beginning of the *Iliad*, the invocation of the muse? Hesiod does this, too. It's almost like Parmenides is setting up a kind of poetic allegory we're very familiar with.
- 2.11** But how does the goddess teach him all things? Here's the difference. The goddess doesn't tell the young man everything there is to know. The goddess gives him the tools to find out all that there is. It's a very symbolic shift that, from being, from downloading all knowledge from the muse to downloading the software, if you like, to learn and discern and understand all things. And again, we have that sense of a new spirit, a new philosophical spirit. That the goddess teaches the young man how to evaluate reality, to test, to reject, to affirm. And the poem, from what we can make of it, is made up of two primary parts, the way of truth, *Aletheia*, and the way of belief, *Doxa*. *Aletheia* and *Doxa*, truth and belief.
- 2.12** So again, we can start to see that distinction between metaphysics, truth, the way reality ultimately is, and belief, epistemology, how we grapple with what there might ultimately be. Parmenides, in the first way, the way of truth, says that Being is ultimate because whatever is, whatever we think about, whatever we talk about, exists. At least it has some mode of existence. Nothing that can be the subject of thought or talk can be nothing. A unicorn is something. We can say true things about unicorns. We can say false things about unicorns. We know how many horns a unicorn has. What are we knowing when we say we know that? A fact? A state of affairs? Yes, it's a fact, but you might say it's a piece of mythology. It's a piece of a mythology that has emerged over time in a particular place in a particular culture and so on.
- 2.13** But for Parmenides, it exists. We can think about unicorns, we can talk about unicorns, we can say true things about unicorns, we can say false things about unicorns. It's not nothing. A unicorn is not nothing. And Parmenides goes on to say that whatever exists cannot, once upon a time, not have existed. Why does he think this? Well, nothing can come from nothing. Whatever exists must exist, can't ever have been in a state of not existing at all. Something must have maybe brought it into existence, and that something also exists, must exist. They share in existence. They share a common ingredient, the most fundamental ingredient.
- 2.14** Whatever can possibly exist can't be nothing at all. If it's got the capacity to exist, it must, as it were, exist, even in some merely possible mode of existence. So what can exist does exist. What we can think of existing, therefore does exist. What does not exist, it cannot exist. It cannot come into existence. There is no possible mode of its existence. The philosopher Ludwig Wittgenstein once said that, "A nothing will do as

well as a something about which nothing can be said." A nothing will do as well as a something about which nothing can be said. If you can't talk about it, says Wittgenstein, if there's something that you can't refer to, you can't talk about, then it might as well be nothing.

- 2.15 Parmenides' idea is not so different from that. He might tweak it a little bit. He might say, "A nothing will do as well as a something about which nothing can be thought." If it's something that just can't even be thought about, then it's nothing. It's not a something. What kind of a thing could it be that isn't possibly the object of thought? Once you say that something is, you can't say that it was, you can't say that it will be. It just belongs at the realm of Being. And although it looks as though things are Becoming and changing at the top, as it were on the surface, that's an illusion. It's an illusion. The world of Becoming is really an illusory realm. And what is real and what is fundamental is all things are. Reality is a single, unchanging unity with the appearance of difference and diversity on the surface.
- 2.16 We can have a whole lecture series looking at the way this tug-of-war between Being and Becoming is the gleaming golden thread that ties much Indian philosophy together. Much Indian philosophy can be understood through this tension, this polarity between the visible realm of Becoming and the ultimate realm of Brahma or reality, undifferentiated reality.
- 2.17 And this brings us nicely onto a theme that characterizes the pre-Socratic chapter of Western philosophy, and as we'll see, Plato and Aristotle, too. In fact, you could say that it's a distinction that runs right through Western philosophy and Eastern philosophy. And it's the distinction between the one and the many, between monism and pluralism, between unity and diversity. You might, in fact, think of the Christian doctrine of God as three in one and God as one in three, the doctrine of the Trinity, as this majestic attempt to cut the Gordian knot, to solve this great oscillation between the one and the many, between unity and plurality, and between unity and plurality, between monism and pluralism. It's an attempt that there is differentiation within a single whole.
- 2.18 You pick any philosopher from the textbooks, and you could probably, pretty plausibly, put that philosopher into the monist corner or the pluralist corner. Parmenides would be in the monist corner. A single, undifferentiated unity. We'll look in a later lecture at the Atomist school. Democritus and Leucippus. That's a school that really thinks of reality as made up of almost infinitely many indivisible units. Everything is plural. Or you might think of dualist ways of understanding reality. The Zoroastrians, the Gnostic schools, think of reality in terms of good and evil. Think of the world of spirit and the world of matter. You still have these grand attempts to bring the two together.
- 2.19 Even debates over mind and body. Are we our minds? Are we conscious? Or are we just our brains? That, in a way, is an attempt to reconcile two fundamentally different categories of Being, a two-tiered ontology. Ontology, the study of the nature of Being.

What do we think makes it onto our list of kinds of Being? But that's for another lecture.

2.20 We have, in Parmenides, the first truly sophisticated metaphysician. In one of Plato's dialogues, he appears as the main subject of the dialogue. The dialogue is called *The Parmenides*. It's by some distance the most difficult and demanding dialogue of Plato's 35-odd dialogues. And what's so striking is that Socrates, though he presents what most philosophers agree were, most historians of philosophy agree, was Plato's take on reality, Plato's metaphysics, Socrates loses. He loses the debate against Parmenides. Parmenides develops devastating objections to Plato's so-called Theory of Forms. So he's an unquestionably great and influential thinker.

2.21 There's that streak of rationalism we see, that sense of not relying on the senses that fool us into thinking that the world of Becoming, what we see is what there is. Focuses on reason. Reflecting on the nature of Being will help us to understand that Being is ultimate, and what does not have Being is not, and therefore cannot be thought about and cannot be talked about. Now, there are all kinds of objections to Parmenides' position. Perhaps the most obvious is the confusion Parmenides gets into when he's talking about that little word 'is'. In Greek, the word 'it is', as 'he' or 'he is' or 'she is' is 'esti'. Irritatingly, and poor old Parmenides, this not poor old Parmenides' fault, 'esti' can also mean 'everything is', 'everything, all things is', 'ta panta esti'. 'Esti' doesn't change in Greek, a neuter plural, all things, all stuff, all things, takes a singular verb. 'Ta panta esti', all of the things just are.

2.22 And there was no distinction either between what's called an existential use of the word 'to be' —Socrates is, i.e., Socrates exists—and the predicative use of the verb 'to be'. Socrates is henpecked. He was, by his wife, Xanthippe, reputedly. This is a predicative use of the verb 'to be'. We're attributing something to Socrates, not making any comment about his existence. Sherlock Holmes is clever. Just because we use the little word 'is' there doesn't mean we're making any existential claims about Sherlock Holmes. And in fact, this distinction is one of the —recognizing this distinction is one of the founding moments of Anglo-American philosophy. It's famously in the writings of Frege and Bertrand Russell. But Parmenides just, he doesn't make this distinction, not really his fault, again, but this leads to lots and lots of philosophical confusions.

2.23 We might also say, look, it's very odd to suppose that something needs to be thought about in order to exist at all. Pluto existed when Parmenides was writing. Nobody had thought, given any thought or thought about Plato, and nobody had ever—Pluto, I should say—and nobody had talked about Pluto. That did not affect the existence of Pluto. So, some of Parmenides' arguments can strike us as rather strange and difficult to take seriously. But that doesn't change the fact that we're standing at the beginnings of abstract thought. The way he's asking the questions about Being itself, about that which would seem to be the ultimate object of cognition, the ultimate layer of all that's

real, and that skepticism towards the notion of there being nothing at all, being able to talk or think about nothing at all, that basic impulse is one that is with us still.

- 2.24** So Parmenides is the great founder of the Eleatic school. Others came after him. Most famously of all, perhaps, Empedocles. Empedocles of Acragas. Acragas is in modern-day Sicily. And Empedocles effectively accepted Parmenides' parameters. He accepted that there is just a single domain of being. But Empedocles argued that we've still got to explain the world of Becoming that's fooling us. We've still got to explain how it is that what we see seems to be in a state of Becoming, seems to exhibit all kinds of differences. So Empedocles said, "Look, I think I can still be consistent with Parmenides," and nevertheless suggests that there are certain building blocks to being, certain ultimate building blocks.
- 2.25** And what Empedocles does, in effect, is to start with two pairs of oppositions that were familiar to the Ionian school, hot and cold, and dry and wet. And the Ionian school, and particularly the Milesians, saw these oppositions as somehow creative and generative, four fundamental modes of existence. But to be understood in material terms. Things are hot. Material things are hot. Material things are cold, dry, wet, and so on. Empedocles tries to draw that materialist framework and marry it to the more non-materialist metaphysical framework of the Eleatics. And he does that by turning those modes of existence into fundamental ingredients of reality. What's hot? That's fire, element one, the dominant element for Empedocles.
- 2.26** What's, he then works through all the other three elements—air, and water, and earth. Water is the rarefied version of wetness, and earth is the rarefied version of dryness, and water is the rarefied material version of wetness. These are the four elements, the four building blocks. But Empedocles recognizes that's not enough. There's still got to be forces that explain how these units of stuff interact and reconfigure themselves, how Being can reconfigure itself into an appearance that we can see and that will be constantly changing.
- 2.27** And so Empedocles thinks that he can appeal to two forces. One, a love. Didn't see that coming. Attraction, you might say, eros, and conflict, strife, tension, opposition, disharmony. In Greek, eris. There's any one vowel different, eros and eris. Love-attraction and repulsion-conflict. Now you might think, well, these are two notions drawn from the human world. Well, yes, remember Anaximenes? This idea, well, maybe all reality is air or depends upon air, just like we depend upon, we need air. Well, love makes the world go round. Love brings new souls into the world. And we see war everywhere, too. We see conflict. So it's not implausible to infer by analogy that this is somehow, that these fundamental features of human experience are a clue to ultimate reality.
- 2.28** And so, taking Parmenides' Being, and understanding it as being exemplified in these four units, fire and water, earth and air, we can understand the world of Becoming that Parmenides is so skeptical about. We can understand the world of Becoming different

things that we see as being different, because the same things, the same ingredients, are being simply reconfigured in different ways, in different proportions, as a result of attraction and repulsion, love and strife, harmony and disharmony. And so, again, we can see this attempt to, which will characterize so much of Western philosophy, the attempt to bring together the world of Becoming and the world of Being. Things coming into Being and slipping out of Being, being explained in terms of Being at the foundational layer.

2.29 We see something similar to this attempt of Empedocles in another figure, beginning with the Greek word 'anax', Anaxagoras, Anaxagoras of Clazomenae. Anaxagoras is a figure who pops up in Athens in the fifth century. The satirist, brilliant writer of comedic theater, Aristophanes, mocks him mercilessly, as he mocks Socrates mercilessly. Anaxagoras attempts a similar fusion of the Ionian and the Eleatic. He agrees with Parmenides, there's no Becoming, there's no coming into Being and passing away. Everything is in everything. Everything is in everything. What does that mean?

2.30 Well, we've talked about Empedocles. Empedocles could have said something similar. Everything, well, there's just four things, and everything you see is made up of those four things, but just to different proportions, and it's organized to different degrees by harmony and disharmony. Everything is everything. The many is one thing, just configured in different ways. He develops this doctrine that Aristotle calls homoeomeroism. That is to say that every part, every 'meros', has within it something that every other part also has. Everything is in everything. I have a piece of gold. It's divisible. I can turn it into two bits of gold, but it's still a bit of gold, no matter how far down you divide it.

2.31 And Anaxagoras thought that you could just keep on dividing all the way down. And this is a big debate in physics at the moment, and it's one of the big debates in philosophy of physics. Is everything divisible to an infinite extent? I mean, obviously, we know about atoms, we know about molecules. We've seen Oppenheimer and so on. We can think in those terms. But though the word atom comes from the Greek impossible to cut, 'temno' meaning to cut, and the alpha being a privative or having a negating force, atomos is literally the indivisible, the uncuttable. We now know that the uncuttable is, in fact, cuttable. We can in fact think, well, even if we can't experiment, even if technology has run out, we can still at least conceive of the notion that maybe a neutrino, maybe one day we'll divide the neutrino.

2.32 And so the metaphysician is thinking, well, how far down does this go? Does there come a point where there is a metaphysically indivisible unit, a spatio-temporal point, perhaps, beyond which it's not thinkable, let alone technologically achievable, to go deeper into smaller parts? Anaxagoras says it's division all the way down. We can divide all the way down. The technical term among contemporary philosophers of physics for this is gunk. I'm not making that up. There are many, many learned articles in some of the finest philosophy journals in the world that are exploring and defending or

criticizing the existence of gunk. A gunky universe, a gunky reality, is a reality that is divisible all the way down, even if our technology will never get there. In principle, it's just gunk all the way down. Everything is infinitesimally divisible.

- 2.33** If you reject that view, you're committed to a pointy view of ultimate reality. That is to say, you're committed to the view that there comes a point where the dividing has to stop, and the ultimate constituents are, quite plausibly, spatio-temporal points. They are points, they have a GPS, they have spatial coordinates, and there's a time when they exist. And those are the candidates for the ultimate units of reality. Anyway, Anaxagoras is a gunky, a philosopher committed to the existence of gunk. But he is also committed to the notion that there are certain seeds, spermata, that explain how it is that one kind of thing can emerge from another thing, inherit certain forms, and these forms can be transmitted.
- 2.34** And these seeds or forms, this is something that Aristotle is going to develop a great deal later on, are how we can come up with a taxonomy of nature, a classification of how different things are what they are, in terms of, in effect, essences will be the key idea that Aristotle brings to the table, inherited to some extent from Plato. So, we have, in the figures of Empedocles and Anaxagoras, philosophers who are operating, who are influenced by Parmenides and operate to accept many of his arguments, and then are trying to keep philosophical inquiry going within those strictures, within the strictures that there cannot be nothing at all. Everything ultimately is, and is a single undifferentiated unity.
- 2.35** But unlike the skepticism that Parmenides seemed to infer from that, skepticism about all sense experience, Anaxagoras and Empedocles attempt to offer a philosophical explanation of how, within that framework, that unified, single, undifferentiated framework, it was possible for there to be different kinds of things. We could experience the world in ways that weren't purely illusory. Parmenides seemed to take us towards a kind of skepticism. Anaxagoras and Empedocles point to a way in which we can say, no, these things that we see every day, everyday experience, has a reality. But the difference is that we see the sheer variety that makes up human experience is to be explained by understanding reality as having different modes of being, and of there being different ingredients that make up a single being.
- 2.36** One little footnote to Anaxagoras. Aristotle says at one point that what sets Anaxagoras apart from all of the babblers who came before him was that he was committed to the existence of 'nous' or mind. Anaxagoras had the nickname translated into English, Mr. Mind. That is to say, Anaxagoras is the first philosopher that we come across who appeals to intelligence, an overarching, originating intelligence or reason or mind that organizes reality. This is something new.
- 2.37** There's a wonderful passage in Plato's Dialogue, the Phaedo, where Socrates talks about hearing this view of Anaxagoras, that mind is the organizer of all things, and talks about how excited and thrilled he was to hear this. But then he quickly got

disappointed. He said, he comes up this incredible idea. Here we've got at last, explanation of the orderliness, the uniformity of reality. An explanation of why the world isn't just completely chaotic. We can now understand it by appealing to the explanatory power of a single organizing intelligence. It's not material, it's not water, it's not air, it's thought. And it may be a mystery appealing to a grand mind, but it's not a puzzle, it's not a problem. Important distinction in philosophy between mysteries and problems.

2.38 Minds appealing to a grand mind that is the source of the order of all things is a pretty mysterious thing to appeal to. It's not something you bump into on the street every day. But it's not a problem. We can get our heads around it, so to speak. Why? Because we have minds. It's something we can understand ourselves, making a toy model of a city, and we can understand explaining the different designs that we've used on those Lego bricks by appealing to the intentions of our minds. It's not repugnant to jump from that to the idea that all of reality is ordered in some way by a supremely rational and supremely powerful being.

2.39 Now, of course, we should have Xenophanes of Colophon and Ludwig Feuerbach ringing in our ears. This is the problem with all religious people and theologians. They just project, project, project. And this is just the horses worshiping an equine deity, et cetera. The oxen are worshiping a bovine deity, and so on and so forth. And the point is well taken. But there are certain features and principles of , certain features of rationality and mind that are very different and that have a philosophical power that a horse does not.

2.40 One of the reasons Socrates is disappointed with Anaxagoras is that he comes up with this great idea of mind being the ultimate explanation of patterns and orders in the world, order in the world. But he stops there, and then he just starts appealing to material things. And indeed, he's allegedly put on trial for a kind of skepticism, a sort of atheism. Very strange. He comes up with the most theistic, metaphysic, and yet he's accused of being an atheist, partly because he doesn't put his theistic intuitions about mind being the organizing principle of reality to work, in explanatory terms. He reverts very quickly to an Ionian approach to explaining and understanding reality, appealing to things, to stuff, material things, mixtures in motion.

2.41 We come now to the final figure for this lecture and for this section of the course. And he's the one philosopher I suspect you will have heard of before starting these lectures. Pythagoras. Pythagoras of Samos. Sometimes he's spoken of as Pythagoras of Croton. Samos is a beautiful island, very close to the coast of modern-day Turkey. This is where Pythagoras was born. We're not quite sure when, let's say the middle of the sixth century, around about 550 BC. But he spends most of his life and dies in Italy, southern Italy, a place called Croton, very near Elea. And although it wouldn't be quite correct to say that he's part of the Eleatic school, he has an approach and outlook that is comparable to the Eleatic vision.

- 2.42 Pythagoras is overwhelmed by the sense of order in the world. In fact, he says that reality is 'kosmos'. Kosmos in Greek means the decorative, the orderly, the patterned. We have our word cosmetics. It comes straight from that, not from the sense of the cosmos, but from the Greek verb 'kosme', to decorate, to beautify, to make beautiful. But in the Greek mind, from Pythagoras onwards, and indeed before Pythagoras, the world was a beautiful place. The world was an orderly place. Wasn't chaos. It was intelligible. This is the most striking thing about it. One of the hardest things to understand about reality, Albert Einstein once said, is that it is understandable. One of the least intelligible things about reality is that it's intelligible.
- 2.43 I mean, what are the chances? What are the chances that it was just intelligible? Think of all the different ways that it could have just been unintelligible. And think of all the different ways that there might never have been a species of featherless bipeds who emerged, who could just understand the world, recognize its order, reason about it. And for Pythagoras, that order, the cosmos, the orderliness of reality, its cosmetics, if you like, had to be understood in, had to be explained in some fundamental way. And as it were, the actual ingredients of reality couldn't themselves be the source of that explanation. Because it's them being in the order that they're in that needs explaining. And they didn't just arrange themselves. These pieces didn't just arrange themselves into being. We're not asking about the bricks. We're asking about the cathedral. What explains that?
- 2.44 If you said, well, this is the quarry that the bricks came from. This is how you explain the cathedral. Well, we'd say that that's not an adequate explanation. It's maybe a partial explanation, but it's nowhere near a complete explanation. What we need is an explanation that transcends just the building blocks that are arranged in a particular way that is what's stimulating the need for explanation. That's what we're looking for. What was Pythagoras's answer? His answer was number. Number is the reason that we have the orderliness that we find in the cosmos, and not just number, forms and proportions.
- 2.45 Pythagoras is fascinated, for example, by the tetraktys, T-E-T-R-A-K-T-Y-S, as it were transliterated into English from the Greek. Think of the number one, add the number two, add three to one plus two, add four to one plus two plus three, you get 10. And that 10 can be arranged in a triangle with four dots along each of the sides. And you could imagine four at the bottom, then three, then two, then one. Pythagoras is fascinated by this, fascinated by the harmonies that numbers can generate, and the arrangement that numbers can generation. Forms. Why is he fascinated? Well, partly because the kind of knowledge that we get from mathematics is, to the Greek mind, certainly to Pythagoras' mind and to Plato's mind later, gold-plated knowledge.
- 2.46 We're worrying about how we know things. Is it just my truth? Is it your beliefs? Is it my imagination, dreams, just conjectures? This is the things that keep epistemology people awake at night in philosophy departments. Well, think of mathematical truths. I mean,

this is surely the paradigm of certainty in, if you're in the knowledge business. Two plus two equals four. If that's not true, nothing is. If that's not true, thought stops. And not only is it true that two plus two equals four, not only is that a bedrock truth, a gold-plated truth, it's a necessary truth. It's a true no matter what. Here's one interesting thing about the claim that 2 plus 2 equals 4. It's always true. It's always been true. Here we found a truth that's insulated against time itself. It's not affected by time at all.

2.47 Here we have a truth that is true no matter where you are in the Mediterranean world, no matter which galaxy you're in, which is true, whether or not there are any galaxies at all, and whether or not the Big Bang occurred, and whether or not God was before the Big Bang or not. It's just true, everywhere, at all times. And so you can see why this has such an attraction to Pythagoras. That exploring mathematics and establishing truths in mathematics is, just as being was for Parmenides, for Pythagoras, seemed to be the most unimpeachably powerful point to start any philosophy at all.

2.48 If 2 plus 2 equals 4, infinitely many things are true. If the number 2 exists, infinitely many things exist. OK, well, or suppose a skeptic says, "No, no, no, no, that doesn't follow." It could be that the sequence of natural numbers runs out. It could be that the sequence of natural numbers at some point just stops. And it's actually finite. It's not infinite. It stops at 400 trillion 364. Now, what would one say to the skeptic there? Well, you just say, add one. What does that plus one equals? But you might also say, well, look, this is a very strange claim, because in philosophy, it's pretty plausible that finite things are much more complicated than non-finite things.

2.49 This is a point that Anaximander seems to be fumbling his way towards when he invokes 'to apeiron', the non-finite, the non-determinate, as the fundamental layer of all reality. It's much less complicated. There is no kind of thing that the ultimate is. It doesn't have any particular mode of existence. It has no characteristics, no properties, no features. There's nothing you can worry about it. You can ask about it. It is free of all of those determinations. To the philosopher, that has a simplicity to it. Again, it may seem like a mystery, but it's free of problems. It's a mystery that's free of problems. The claim that the sequence of natural numbers is infinite may be a mystery, but it's not a problem. Stopping it, anywhere you care to stop it, we can then ask, why? Why there?

2.50 This is one reason, by the way, that Abrahamic monotheism has been always committed to the idea that God is infinite. God has infinite being, and is, for that reason, simple. It doesn't need any, it doesn't depend upon any other kind of explanation. A flying spaghetti monster is crying out for a whole load of explanations. A flying spaghetti monster, beloved of the new atheists, is putting a whole load of problems on the table in a way that the God of Abrahamic monotheism is not, and in a way, plausibly, that numbers and mathematics do not. Because we can say to the person that asks, "Well, why does the number 2 exist?" We can say, "It just does." I mean, it just does. "Why does 2 plus 2 equals 4?" the child will ask. And you can say,

"Well, you haven't fully understood the nature of that truth if you're wondering what makes it true. It just is true." You just see it.

- 2.51** You don't need to inspect it. Once you see it, you see it. You don't need to go around putting a pair of apples and a pair of oranges together and just making sure and checking that it always comes, adds up to four. There's something that is almost self-explanatory about it. It doesn't depend on sense experience, and it's true no matter what. So, suggests Pythagoras, it's through mathematics that we have the best clue, the best starting point, for inquiring into the nature of everything else.
- 2.52** And this, by the way, is why he thought the most, or seems to have thought, the most important form of human activity is music. Music is, you might say, a number in motion. Music is an endlessly interesting philosophical form of human activity, more so than any kind of literature. Any literature, any poetry, is expressed in a natural language. A particular language, you've got to learn the grammar, you've got to learn the vocabulary, you've got to learn it. Music is a form of communication that doesn't rely on really anything except our sensory kit, our ears, our sense of hearing. And what has fascinated many philosophers, many thinkers in all traditions, is the deep complicity and interconnectedness between mathematics, mathematical harmonies and musical harmonies, between the proportion we find in music and the proportions we find in mathematics.
- 2.53** And so we start to see in Pythagoras, we see in the Pythagorean school, a fascination with music, with musical intervals, and so on. And in fact, this is not, this approach of Pythagoras's is not —it's one that is very easy to relate to in the 21st century, if we just cast our eye across at what the best physicists are doing, most of it, almost all of it, is mathematics. In fact, we've got to the point now where mathematical physics vastly outstrips our capacity to test our findings. I think it's Peter Higgs who came up with the Higgs boson particle. He did this with a pencil and paper. It took him many years. It was a conjecture. For many years, people thought it might be true, might not be true, but it took nearly three decades to be able to establish, empirically, through , by scientific means, to test by the scientific method what he had worked out at his desk through mathematics.
- 2.54** Look at string theory, controversial theory about the nature of ultimate, or the nature of ultimate physical reality. It's all mathematics. That's all it is. They are way beyond the point of stating claims that could be empirically tested in a lab for many, many hundreds of years. So Pythagoras's impulse in his intuition is one that is, seems perfectly plausible. It seems odd to deny that mathematical truths are true. It seems odd to deny, most inconceivable to deny, that they don't pick out, as it were, bedrock truths. They aren't bedrock truths.
- 2.55** Now, this position is troubling to a particular mindset today. We live in a culture that is shaped more than anything by the astonishing success of the natural sciences over the last 250 years. And that has brought with it a habit of thought, a deep presupposition,

that the ultimate arbiter of what's real, what counts as real, what counts as really existing, is what's scientifically testable. Scientists are the great high priests of the modern age. Follow the science. And with that comes a philosophical outlook that insists that all truths are ultimately scientific truths, or reducible to scientific truths. You think you're conscious, you think you're free, but actually, neuroscience tells us that there's all these things going on in your brain, and that's what makes you think you're conscious.

- 2.56** We can call this basic outlook in contemporary philosophy naturalism. Naturalism, or sometimes physicalism. The view that all truths are scientifically testable. Physical truths, natural truths. Pythagoras, in insisting that actually non-material mathematical truths are true, is saying that what's ultimate is not scientific truths. What would a scientific proof of the claim, $2 + 2 = 4$, look like? It wouldn't look like anything. Why? Because it's not a scientific truth. Science can't tell us that mathematical truths are true. It can't come up with a proof that mathematical truths are true, partly because science presupposes mathematics to be true. It couldn't even get off the ground without assuming that mathematical truths are true. But if a mathematical truth is a truth, there are infinitely many truths that are not scientific truths.
- 2.57** Now, there are ways around this, and there are counters to that which we might go into in a later lecture. But for now, I just want to leave you with that final thought that is, even if Pythagoras isn't quite a member of the Eleatic school, is one that is characteristic of the Eleatic outlook. That is looking beyond the material world for some ultimate organizing principle in virtue of which the world exhibits the order and the pattern and the intelligibility that it does. And in our next lecture, we're going to see, arguably, the greatest attempt to fuse these two domains of reality together, Being and Becoming, into a single, stunning vision. We're going to turn to the thought of Plato. Thanks for listening.
- 2.58** Yeah, so I want to go back to one thing you said about the logos, and particularly when you said in John, when he writes, 'en arche en ho logos.' What would that mean then to the Greek audience? Is John making the point that he's following Heraclitus and saying that the logos is the ultimate reality, or what's he saying there?
- 2.59** Well, there's a lot of debate about this, and I think I will touch on it when we talk about the Stoics, because if John is responding to any philosophical mood or idea in the air about logos, it's the Stoic conception of what logos is, and I doubt that he's ever heard of Heraclitus. And of course, it's one of those words that has got such a limitless semantic scope that can be almost all the philosophers are using, are talking about logos, sometimes logoi. So I think if John has any, if he has any philosophical baggage in mind or language in mind, it's the Stoics, who are committed to the ultimate intelligibility of reality. And that ultimate intelligibility is what it is because of a kind of logos that runs through it like a thread, and that's what explains all things.

- 2.60 And so in effect, you could see that what John is saying is he's trying to turn a Hebraic idea into a Hellenic idea. So he's trying to say —well, I say Hebraic, I mean, it is an astonishing claim what's going on in the opening verses of John, because Hebrew thought can't cope with the idea that a human being could be God. And Greek thought can't cope with the idea that a human being could be logos, could be the source of all order and patterns. It could just about cope with the idea that mind is the source of all order. We see it with Mr. Mind, Anaxagoras, and we see it in a late dialogue of Plato, the *Timaeus*. And in that dialogue, there's a kind of demiurge, like he's not quite God, but something with godlike powers, who creates the world according to certain geometric patterns and numbers. So you can see already the fingerprints of Pythagoras on that idea.
- 2.61 But no, although John is not trying to do philosophy, he is, what you find in the New Testament, and in John in particular, are claims that have no hinterland. I mean, they just come from nowhere. They come from nowhere. They then become the most generative source of philosophizing for the next two millennia. But though it's fashionable to try and say, "Oh, John had this in mind, this philosophy," it's something that emerges from a clear blue sky. He's not even a philosopher. He doesn't even claim to be a philosopher. He's skeptical of books being something that could contain what he's writing about.
- 2.62 My colleague at Cambridge, George van Kooten, has probably written the best work on this, Paul among the, Paul among Greek philosophy. So I'd point you to his work. But no, the logos is a principle that runs through the Hellenic and the Hebraic. It's everywhere, really. And John's aware of that, and he understands the appeal of it.

Lecture 3: Plato's Perspective

At a glance — Plato's perspective.

- 3.1** In the first two lectures of this series, we looked at two schools, two ways of thinking about philosophical problems. We looked at the Ionian school in the first lecture, and we looked at the Eleatic school in the second lecture. We're now hurtling into the fifth century BC, the so-called classical age. You might think all of this whole period is classical. In fact, historians simply refer to this particular period as the classical period, the fifth century. We're in the archaic age up until the late sixth century. We're now moving into the classical age, which we might say begins with, let's say, the fall of Miletus, the sacking of Miletus, by the Persians in 496 BC, and we might say, ending with the death of Plato in 347 BC. That's a rough periodization, but it's a helpful way for us to think.
- 3.2** We're now entering into the golden age of Hellenic thought. That golden age was anchored, and not so much in Ionia, because really, by this point, the Greek-speaking world of Ionia is being corroded, captured, and conquered by the new and mighty Persian empire under Xerxes and Darius. In the West, the city-states of Magna Graecia are settling down and now really their own independent, autonomous city-states. And so the focus turns now to Attica that lies midway, roughly, between Italy and Ionia, the western coast of modern-day Turkey, and in particular, the city state of Athens, the polis of Athens. This the word 'polis' is going to come up again and again.
- 3.3** It's difficult to exaggerate what an extraordinary efflorescence of human genius we find in this short period. In the fifth century BC, in this small city, numbering no more than maybe 25, 30,000 citizens, albeit underpinned by a massive slave class, we see the emergence for the first time of theater. Nobody had done theater before, until a man called Thespis is reputed to have put on a mask at the annual feast of the Dionysia in Athens, celebrating the god Dionysus, and to have been the first to pretend to be somebody else in this procession. The date given for this is about 546 BC, but really, that's the moment that is seen as the beginning of theater.
- 3.4** It's the point at which we see the emergence of tragedy, literally the goat song. 'Tragos' in Greek means goat, 'ode' means song. Goat song. Why? Because the goat is what was sacrificed at the climax of the festivities in honor of the god Dionysus. It's a religious festival. That is the roots, the origins of theater. We have tragedy. We have the three great tragedians of classical Athens, Aeschylus, Sophocles, and then Euripides. We then see, halfway through the fifth century, the emergence of another kind of theater, the village song, the 'ode' of the 'kome', of the village, the 'kome ode', the comedy. We see here the beginnings of political satire, humor, irreverence.
- 3.5** Roughly halfway through the fifth century, we see a figure who emerges. He's not an Athenian, but Athens is the place that incubates the intellectual intensity underpinning

this man's work. *Apodeixis tas historias*. This is a revelation of the inquiry, *historia*, of Herodotus of Halicarnassus. *Historia*, inquiry, the first historian that we now think of, at least the first work that falls plausibly within the category of what we now understand to be history. If you read Herodotus's *Histories* now, it can read more like anthropology. But it's the first time somebody systematically sets down and starts trying to write about the past in a rational way, in a way that doesn't invoke mythological, but that treats mythological explanations with a measure of skepticism, not full skepticism all the time. Herodotus is willing to believe all kinds of fancy, fanciful stories. And he remains probably one of our best sources for the culture of Egypt and Persia at the time.

3.6 Shortly after Herodotus, we find the great Athenian general, Thucydides, starts to write his own kind of history, which is probably a lot more what we would associate, what we now think of as history, stressing economic explanation, military explanation, the role of charismatic personalities in decision-making and in the fortunes of his city-state, and the shaping of human affairs by economic and military forces. And all of this is happening when Athens is, for most of the fifth century, in a state of total war. The first half of the fifth century, it's in a state, it's in a civilizational struggle with the empire of Persia.

3.7 Athens successfully defeats Persia with a tiny army. The asymmetries in numbers are exaggerated a little bit by Herodotus, but it was still an uneven contest, and yet they won in 490 on the plain of Marathon. And they won again 10 years later when the Persians regrouped. The Battle of Salamis, and famously, with Spartan support and the support of other city-states at Thermopylae, and at the Battle of Plataea. And then there followed a couple of decades of relative stability in which Athens organized a Delian League, a league of Greek city-states and islands centered on the island of Delos, which is the middle island of the Cyclades in the Mediterranean. This became, as it were, a NATO alliance to hold in check the might of Persia. And it was very successful.

3.8 And yet, over time, and we can see this from the inscriptions, the language moves from the Delian League, the allies, 'hoi symmakhoi', to 'hoi Athenaioi kai toi symmakhois,' to the Athenians and their allies, to simply the Athenians. And the treasury, supporting their NATO alliance, is moved from Delos to Athens itself, to the Acropolis in Athens. And the great building projects of Athens are undertaken really using the subsidies from all these members of this Delian League, this NATO alliance. Athens starts to get too big for its boots. Sparta, highly militaristic, sees Athens as the emerging power, and there begins, in the 440s BC, the first of a series of devastating conflicts between Athens and Sparta, or the Athenians and their, those loyal to them, and the Spartans and those loyal to Sparta.

3.9 And really for that, from the 440s right up to 404 BC, Athens, as I said, is in a state of total war. Plague hits in the 420s. There's a catastrophic expedition to Sicily in 415 BC. All of this is described in mesmerizing detail in Thucydides' history of the Peloponnesian

War. And yet, despite all this, we can still refer to this period as one of the great golden ages in human genius, in human culture, in human thought. Simply astonishing. Perhaps only the Elizabethan golden age comes close. And even there, that golden age under Elizabeth in the late 16th century really expressed itself primarily through theater and poetry. Nothing like the range of the Athenian golden age.

3.10 One of the revolutions that occurs in the fifth century, which I haven't mentioned yet, is the emergence of a preference for people power, 'to kratos tou demou', the power of the people. This begins to emerge under some reforms undertaken by a guy called Cleisthenes in 507, 506 BC. And then moving into the fifth century, you have a radical democracy. I say radical in the sense that it's not representative democracy. It's a direct democracy on really every single decision, including military decisions. This is something we've not seen before. This is a radical innovation in how society is organized. And looking at the wreckage that Athens is in, in 404 BC, we won't be surprised to learn that a lot of thinkers who emerge in the fourth century, including the great figure we're going to be looking at in this lecture and the next lecture, express profound skepticism towards democracy as an ideal form of government.

3.11 What's happening with philosophy at this time? Well, one phenomenon that begins in the early fifth century is the professionalization of philosophy. In as much as a class emerges that understands that there's now power in being able to advance good arguments, or rather, arguments that win over voters, that can win over an assembly, suddenly we have a clear application for clever argument. And that is the Athenian Ecclesia, the large group of about 10,000 citizens who had voting powers, and in the Boule, where all the decisions were taken, the 500-strong Boule, led by a president who was elected every day. Presidential tenure lasts 24 hours.

3.12 And so there suddenly emerged a commercial motive for being able to advance clever arguments. But the degree to which those arguments needed to track truth was another matter entirely. When we were looking at the Ionians and the Eleatics, we were dealing, really, with aristocrats, figures who most likely didn't need to work very much, living in cultures of relative affluence, and there was no real financial incentive for them to spin clever arguments. They were simply committed to tracking truth, to inquiring into the world. This emerging class of super-tutors, you might say, were known as the 'sophistae', the wise people, the purveyors of wisdom.

3.13 And to begin with, this didn't have the pejorative sense that the word 'sophists', or sophistic, now has today. To begin with, the sophists were brilliant people, learned people, almost always people from outside Athens who had come to Athens, now that it was emerging as the central power in the eastern half of the Mediterranean. Prodicus of Ceos, Hippias of Elis, Gorgias of Leontini, Protagoras of Abdera. All of these figures were well-read, learned, and capable of advancing arguments that introduced, I think, quite a healthy note of skepticism in Greek thought. Skepticism towards received

wisdom, skepticism towards the Homeric tradition as the repository of human wisdom about human affairs.

- 3.14** The two great Homeric poems had something like the same function as the Bible might have done in America, at least until recently, and probably still does today. It had a canonical and authoritative status that was effectively unrivaled. But we start to see the seeds of skepticism emerging in the sophistic tradition. Protagoras of Abdera, for example, is well known for coining the phrase that 'man is the measure of all things,' a kind of radical anthropocentrism that led, in the eyes of his critics, to a radical relativism. The truth was really up to whatever human beings decided was the case.
- 3.15** In that turn, we see the emergence of something like humanism. That is to say, a shift away from the concerns that we find in the Ionian school and in the Eleatic school. You might have noticed in the first two lectures that human beings don't appear very much in the scope of inquiry. It's all about ultimate reality. It's about Being and Becoming and so on and so forth. These are very abstract notions. We can sometimes feel that today, I think, when we're talking to physicists who say, "Well, really, all reality is just atoms or something strange going on at the subatomic world, and that's all really reality is." I don't know about you, but my response to that is, "Well, what difference does that make? What difference does it make to my life? What difference does it make to the flourishing of society? What difference does it make at all?"
- 3.16** There's a sense of irrelevance to that intellectual tradition. We have something like, in the sophistic tradition, we have a shift towards the human, human affairs. Who are we? What matters to us? What should matter to us? And how do we decide that? How do we get on with one another? How do we organize ourselves? Of course, this is a time at which Athenians are becoming more and more aware that the way in which a society is organized politically isn't timeless and fixed and anchored. It is up for grabs. Most of them would have known people involved in drafting new constitutions. Aristotle, as we'll see later on, describes 158 constitutions in his politics and goes through each of them and tries to classify them.
- 3.17** And so it's very, very difficult then to believe somebody like, well, the Spartans who insisted that their constitution was divine, devised by Lycurgus and blessed by gods. It seems difficult to accept that kind of mythological origin story. And yet the sophists present a problem. They take money very often for their teaching, for their speeches. They're committed to offering to the highest bidder a pedagogical formation for the brilliant young, the gilded youth of Athens, that will help them get ahead in the democratic assembly, that will help them make fine-sounding speeches. And the way to start to understand the figure we're looking at in these next two lectures is as a kind of allergic reaction to this tradition, an allergic reaction to the sophists.
- 3.18** I'm referring, of course, to Plato. He's born in about 429 BC to an aristocratic family. He was heavy-set; he was a wrestler. He wanted to be a playwright when he was young. And the story is told, almost certainly apocryphal, that on the day he met his great

teacher, he decided to burn all of the tragedies that he'd written to that point and to give up his vocation to be a competitive tragedian, because he had found the great subject of his life's work in this great teacher. That teacher, of course, was Socrates, Socrates of Athens, born in 470 BC, and dies by hemlock in 399 BC, after a famous trial in which he was accused of corrupting the youth and introducing new gods. Corrupting the youth and introducing new gods.

- 3.19** Those accusations are interesting because they're the kind of accusations that were typically associated with the sophists, who Plato, throughout all of his dialogues, is at pains to attack as he celebrates and champions the figure of Socrates as the great antidote to sophistic thinking. But maybe it's easy to be a little bit too hard on the Athenian authorities. After all, two of Socrates's students, Alcibiades and [Critias], proved to be disastrous for Athens. Alcibiades was well known for having betrayed Athens and gone over to the other side, gone over to the Spartan side, at various points. And Critias was a diabolically disastrous oligarch who put to death many fine Athenians in the chaos of the last decade of the fifth century.
- 3.20** And the second charge, introducing new gods, is one that would have had a relevance, would have had a real force, in a culture where civic religion was a source of social stability. Even if there was room for skepticism about the Homeric gods, nevertheless, these religious festivals were crucial for securing a sense of self-identity for the city-state and a sense of order and protocol. And in fact, Socrates is offered the choice, and this is recounted in the work of Plato that I would recommend you start with if you haven't read any Plato already. That is the *Apology*. The *Apology*, not really a dialogue as most of the rest of Plato's works are—it's really just one long, brilliant speech by Socrates, in which it's made clear that the Athenian judges offered him a choice between exile and death.
- 3.21** Or rather, he was offered an alternative. First of all, he was offered an alternative sentence, and he suggested that Athens should grant on him the free gift of being a public benefactor for the rest of his life. Free meals in the central canteen of Athens for the rest of his life, because he had done so much good to the city. The judges didn't like that. He accepts his sentence. His friends beg him in his prison cell to escape. He could have escaped, but he refuses. And the grounds for his refusal are found in the *Crito* dialogue, in which he says, "I've got a lot, I've derived over the course of my life a great deal of benefit from the laws of this city. And even if those laws are unjust, it would be a greater injustice for me to disobey them. The laws, the *nomoi*, are what provide the anchoring stability and order of the city-state. And so I'm not going to escape. I'm going to stay here."
- 3.22** And then we have, in the most moving dialogue of Plato, the *Phaedo*, arguably one of the great literary highlights of the Western tradition, an incredibly moving conversation, Socrates's final conversations, the only dialogue in which Socrates laughs. He laughs in the face of death. And the dialogue is a meditation on death and a

meditation on immortality. The Phaedo contains some of those brilliant arguments that Plato advances for, or that any Greek philosopher advances, for the immortality of the soul, for the claim that biological death is not death. So that's where I would start. Start with the Apology, start with the Crito, start with the Phaedo. It's this extraordinary fusion of philosophy and drama. You can see, in the pages of these dialogues, Plato's original vocation to be a tragedian.

- 3.23** What's going on in those dialogues? Why the dialogues? Seems so strange. We noted, when we were talking about the Ionian school and the Eleatic school, that the fragments, to the extent we can reconstruct them, were very often dactylic hexameters. They were done in a Homeric style of poetry. There's some prose, too. But there's certainly no sense that it's anything other than a monologue, a statement, a treatise by a single author. In fact, there's very little interaction, it seems, as I said, between members of these different schools. They don't quote each other much. They don't refer to each other much. It's quite a disaggregated school. They're all independent, and they are all advancing their own particular ways of tackling the different problems that they're addressing.
- 3.24** But in Plato, we find up to around about 35 dialogues. Conversations. And here's the extraordinary thing. Plato doesn't say anything in any of them. He appears once, and his absence is noted in another dialogue. But there is no character in these dialogues called Plato, who says anything as Plato. One of the dialogues, the Phaedrus, takes place outside the city under a tree, under the plane tree, 'hypo tou platonos', underneath the Plato tree. A plane tree, Plato, it's a pun. And that's a nice metaphor. And clearly, Plato knew what he was doing when he said that, underneath the Plato tree. He was a literary genius as well as a philosophical genius. He wrote some of the finest classical Greek prose that has survived.
- 3.25** It's a good metaphor because that's how we understand his presence in all of the dialogues. He's everywhere and nowhere. The great French novelist Gustave Flaubert, I was reading this morning in one of his letters, describes how important it is for the author to be like this, to be like God in the novel. Everywhere and nowhere. And that's certainly true of Plato, the first great writer of prose in the West, the first great literary artist, literary prose stylist.
- 3.26** So they're conversations; they're dialogues, typically divided into three phases, the early, middle, and later. We don't need to go into the various arguments as to whether it's a good idea to carve things up that way. But it's probably true to say that the early dialogues do reflect a historical kernel of conversations or an amalgam of conversations, that did in fact happen, populated by characters who would have known each other very well, and who were almost entirely historical characters, drawn from the fascinating cast of Athenian citizens of the last, let's say, the last third of the fifth century.

- 3.27** And they, Plato begins writing them after the trial of Socrates, so these are fourth-century works. He's beginning to write in the 390s, in the 380s, and all the way up to his death, in 347 BC. But he chooses conversation, he chooses dialogue. Maybe that's part of that longing for the vocation of the dramatist that he grew up with. But it's very clear, after just a few pages of reading any of these dialogues, what a powerful tool he has discovered for philosophical inquiry. Because he invents, in effect, through dialogue form, a technique in philosophy. The technique is called, the technical term is dialectic. 'Dialektikos.' It comes from the word 'dialogismai', 'dialégesthai', to engage in dialogue. Dialektikos is the distilled version of a dialogue, distilled dialogue.
- 3.28** And the basic idea underpinning this method is that truth-seeking is collaborative. It's collaborative inquiry. John Stuart Mill famously says in chapter two of On Liberty, 1859, that one of the reasons free speech is so important is that nobody has a monopoly on truth. It's very unlikely that you're right about everything. But you're not going to know what you're wrong about if you're not exposing your ideas to the crucible of scrutiny and disagreement. Chances are, says Mill, you're right about some stuff and you're wrong about other stuff, and you're not going to be able to work out which bits are right and which bits are wrong if you haven't exposed your arguments to criticism.
- 3.29** And finally, he says, he who knows only his own side knows little of that. Even if you are completely right, you're never really going to know that you are, unless you've exposed your arguments to dialogical critique and scrutiny. Plato gets this immediately. As it were, this is baked into his method. You advance a thesis, it's criticized, it's refined, it's, bits of it are affirmed, bits of it are rejected, and then you've got a refined model to start again with, and then that process keeps going, keeps going.
- 3.30** And this characterizes most of the dialogues, certainly the early dialogues. A lot of the early dialogues can be quite frustrating to read. Most of them end inconclusively, without any answers at all. Many of those early dialogues are simply very polite interrogations by Socrates of some noble figure drawn from the 'kaloi kagathoi', the beautiful and the good, the great and the good, of the Athenian elite. So, for example, in the Laches, the dialogues are named after the main figure, the main dialogue partner, or Socrates' main victim in the dialogue. The Laches, Laches is the name of an Athenian general, the dialogue turns on the question of courage. What's courage? 'Ti esti andreia?'
- 3.31** 'If anyone's going to know what courage is, surely it's you, O Laches. You have such an extraordinary track record. Look at all those medals on your breast. Surely you will know what courage is. You can clear some of these confusions and difficulties that I've been having, pinning down just what courage is, what it is we're talking about when we're talking about courage. It seems important that we should know what we're talking about when we're talking about such a great virtue.'
- 3.32** Laches says, 'Well, of course, you've come to the right person. Courage is endurance,' he says. Courage is endurance. 'Thank you,' says Socrates. 'I knew when I was trying to

find the answer to the question, what is courage, that you were the man to come to. And now you've given me this answer. Thank you. I can go away satisfied, except there's just one little thing.' Those of you, you're probably too young for this, you might remember the detective series Columbo, this disheveled American detective who, after the miscreant, the criminal, has given his elaborate excuse as to why, his alibi, his elaborate excuse as to why he couldn't possibly have done the crime, Columbo leaves and goes, 'Just one more thing.' And of course, that one more thing is a devastating objection that brings the entire alibi or story crashing to the ground.

3.33 So Socrates will go, 'Just one more thing. Is courage always a good thing?' But Laches says, 'Yes, of course.' But Socrates says, 'Aren't there all sorts of examples of where endurance is not a good thing? What about gamblers? What about the gambling addict? Doesn't he have extraordinary powers of endurance to face up to massive financial loss day after day? That's a endurance. But would we call it a good thing? But you've said that courage is endurance and that it's a good thing.' And so Laches gets hot and bothered and tries to shore up, desperately shores up his defenses. And Socrates just keeps going, he keeps going. And by the end of the dialogue, nothing is clear. And everything is clear.

3.34 We're clear that we've got no idea what courage is. The greatest general of Athens doesn't know what it is. Socrates still doesn't know what it is. And we're left none the wiser. And yet we've learned the power and value of philosophical failure. The power and value of philosophical failure. Plato is very relaxed at the beginning of his career to show, to show up, to illuminate the extent of ignorance in this city-state. A city-state, recall, that isn't just any city-state. One of the city-state that is in the midst of this extraordinary intellectual and cultural renaissance.

3.35 It turns out, nobody knows much about anything at all. Laches doesn't know what courage is. Euthyphro doesn't know what piety is in that dialogue. In the Charmides, it turns out nobody has any idea what temperance is. In the Lysis, nobody can give a definition of friendship. In the Hippias Major, there's no sense that anyone's got a clue how to answer the question, what is beauty? And if you like, the chronic failure of these early dialogues is the great motivating engine of the dialogues that come later, of Plato's great middle period in particular.

3.36 And what you see in this middle period is a slight shift in the style of the dialogues. There's a sense that the historical figure of Socrates is beginning to recede a bit into the background, even as his speeches get longer. So Socrates, as the creation of Plato, gets more prominent, but it's quite clear that what's going on here is that we're starting to hear a lot more of Plato and a lot less of Socrates. The dialogue form remains, but Socrates' speeches get longer. The wreckage of his interlocutor's arguments, as it were, implicitly gives permission to Socrates to start talking a little bit more. And indeed, a lot more as the middle period moves on.

- 3.37** And it's in this middle period that we have the great dialogues of the *Gorgias*, the *Meno*, the *Phaedo*, the *Phaedrus*, the *Symposium*, and of course, the 10 books of *The Republic*, Plato's second longest dialogue. Let's just go through some of them. The *Gorgias* dialogue focuses on Gorgias of Leontini, who was a well-known sophist who said that there is nothing, nothing can be known, and offers parodies of Parmenides, clever rhetorical parodies of Parmenides, the great founder of the Eleatic school, who we discussed in the previous lecture. And in the *Gorgias*, it's a terrific dialogue. The conversation turns on morality, what morality is, what education is, what virtue is. And we start to see the emergence of a kind of thuggish, might-makes-right vision of morality.
- 3.38** In the figure of Polus and Calicles in the dialogue, in the *Gorgias* dialogue, we start to see this proto-Nietzschean, proto-Machiavellian way of thinking about ethics, really in terms of power. 'Justice,' says another character in the opening book of the *Republic*, 'is nothing other than pursuing the advantage of the stronger party.' 'To sympheron tou kreittonos,' the advantage of the stronger. And this ethic, if you can call it that, dominates the moral universe of late 5th-century Athens. And indeed, there are some terrifying incidents recorded, particularly in Thucydides' *History of the Peloponnesian Wars*, notably Book 5, where this 'might makes right' ethic leads to genocidal results.
- 3.39** Effectively, the Athenians demand allegiance from the people of the island of *Milos*, threatening them, threatening all males with execution and all women and children with slavery if they don't join the Athenian side against Sparta. The *Milians* refuse, and the massacre occurs. And we see glimpses of the logic animating that massacre in the pages of the *Gorgias*. You see Socrates really confronting this. You see a sense of Plato's deep disquiet with this way of thinking. And of course, this prompts the question, well, what is justice? It can't be that. So what is it? How are we to think about it? This becomes the great engine of the *Republic*, the greatest dialogue Plato produces, and arguably, the greatest work of philosophy ever composed.
- 3.40** In the *Meno*, we have a fascinating inquiry into the nature of knowledge, the nature of virtue, particularly mathematical knowledge. Socrates uses a slave boy and guides him through certain mathematical geometric problems, but in a way where it becomes clear that, very quickly, he doesn't need any help. The slave boy, without any education at all, is able to work out geometric puzzles that Socrates puts to him. How is this possible? How is the knowledge in there, inside? It's not derived from experience. We see in the *Meno* the beginnings of a theory of knowledge, epistemology, that is much more fully developed and worked through in the *Republic*.
- 3.41** The *Phaedo*, we've already talked about *Phaedo*, that moving dialogue describing the last hours of Socrates, in which Socrates argues that the soul is immortal. And we start to see in the *Republic* the way in which the problem with the slave boy gets connected to the claims that Socrates makes about the soul. Maybe mathematical knowledge is knowledge that the soul picks up in some prior existence. If the soul is going through

each phase of—is going through a biological life one after another, maybe this knowledge that doesn't seem to be derived from any particular life is attained in some Platonic heaven. That argument is developed also in the Republic. And so on and so forth.

- 3.42** I can't go through all of the different dialogues, but the Symposium is a majestic work as well. The Phaedrus is a stunning dialogue with a famous image of the soul as a charioteer, trying to harness a black horse and a white horse, the black horse being the appetites, the white horse being courage, reason, and the soul is trying to hold these two in harmony. This image is, if you like, a distillation of Plato's psychology. Psychology, the logos of the 'psyche', a conception of the soul, the psyche. And again, this will be a very important recurring feature of the Republic. So we see in all these dialogues the emergence of something like Platonic philosophy, even though, as I said, Plato never says a word.
- 3.43** The later dialogues become less literary. They're more analytic. A lot of the irony and imagery and the characterization is now being directed at ideas and arguments. The figure of Socrates almost vanishes. He gets defeated, famously, in the Parmenides. And in some of the later dialogues, he's not present at all. It's in the Republic, that high point of the middle period, that all of Plato's greatest insights are contained. We have a fascination with justice. 'Ti esti dikaiosune? What is justice?' is the starting point of the dialogue. And the opening book, you have the thuggish Thrasymachus, very similar to Calicles and Polus in the Gorgias, who pushes the 'might is right' answer to the question, 'What is justice?'
- 3.44** And you have at the end Book 1 of the Republic, a philosophical failure, or 'aporia', literally meaning a cul-de-sac. Not quite sure what a cul-de-sac is in American. Is it a cul-de-sac? It's French, anyway. It's not exactly King's English. So it's a dead end. Aporia. Poria is a path; a, the negative, alpha, the alpha privative. There's no way out. A lot of these dialogues end with that sense of, well, there's no way out. And that's true of the end of the opening book of the Republic.
- 3.45** But we start to see hints, even in that book, just as we start to see hints in the early dialogues, that Socrates is diagnosing this philosophical failure as a failure to take seriously the idea that there are stable definitions because there is some stable feature of underlying reality that those definitions are hooking onto. That's the beginning of Socrates's metaphysics. You see it a little bit in the Euthyphro, for example, which turns on the question of what piety is. It ends in failure, but it looks as if Socrates is trying to press the idea that what piety is, is, what holiness is, is not whatever the gods say that it is, but that which the gods recognize as holy and worthy. 'To osion.' Somehow, that's something that even the gods, even the Homeric pantheon, has to measure up to, has to recognize.
- 3.46** Now, it's just left hovering at the end of that dialogue, the Euthyphro, but you can see there something like the basis of the charge that will come later. That Socrates is

introducing new gods, troubling new ideas that are disturbing Athenian polytheism, Athenian civic religion, and therefore, by extension, Athenian social order. Now, it's not until the Republic, really, that we start to see the emergence of a more fully worked-out version of Socrates's, those latent intuitions of Socrates, where it seemed as if Socrates was heading. Stable features of reality that anchor our definitions, that make them true. True no matter what. True in such a way that Protagoras, that falsifies Protagoras's claim that man is the measure of all things.

- 3.47** And these features of reality, Plato argues through his interlocutors, through his characters in the Republic, if they are going to provide that kind of stable anchoring to definitions, to the words that we use, the things that we think, must be stable, and can't, therefore, be rooted in the contingent. Can't be rooted in the empirical. Can't be rooted in what's here today and gone tomorrow. You start to see here the fingerprints of Parmenides. This idea that, for something to be really true, no matter what, it can't be moored in the realm of Becoming, in the realm of coming to be and ceasing to be, because it wouldn't have the stability that we want to give it, that we want a philosophical definition to have.
- 3.48** We talked in the last lecture about Pythagoras and the metaphysical power of mathematics. It's the attraction of an ontology, of a theory of being that is rooted in number. There's something very stable about mathematical truths. They're far truer, if you like, than scientific truths. If, in 50 years' time, our grandchildren were reading the physics textbooks of today, we'd be a little concerned. If they were reading the maths textbooks of today in 50 years time, we'd be pleased, relieved. Mathematics doesn't change in the way that science changes. Science thrives on change. That's in many ways what science is, constantly trying to seek that balance between dogma, extreme dogmatism, and extreme skepticism. Always being willing to test. To test received, seemingly settled scientific truths.
- 3.49** It is a strange age that we live in, that science should have the canonical authority that it does. When it is a method of human inquiry, that almost by definition is changing, where success means disproving or qualifying or rejecting or affirming in different ways the wisdom of previous scientists. We'd be very troubled if mathematicians were overturning Pythagoras's theorem. You can't overturn Pythagoras's theorem or Fermat's last theorem. Why? Because it's a theorem. It's not a theory. Theories can be tested; theories can be disproved. To say that something is a theorem is to say that it's been proven for all time.
- 3.50** In fact, it's strictly misleading to talk of scientific proof at all. There are no scientific proofs. There is no scientific finding that is not susceptible to being refuted. Karl Popper says that that's the hallmark of science, falsifiability. If something, a scientific truth, is true, but it must be falsifiable. It must be a way of—it's true because it hasn't yet been falsified. Plato grasps the importance of finding a realm of reality that is immune to refutation in something like the way mathematics is. This is his claim.

- 3.51** Indeed, in the ideal city that the Republic devotes much of its time to sketching out, the 'kallipolis', the beautiful city, the ideal utopia, citizens are required to have—or the philosopher rulers, those charged with running the city—have to spend years and years and years studying geometry. They've got to study geometry before they can even start on philosophical dialectic. Why? Well, almost certainly because of this deep, tight analogy that Plato insists on drawing between the solidity and necessity of mathematical truth and what he wants to see, the solidity and necessity he wants to see, in, shall we say, human truth. Truths that pertain to the human condition. Justice, courage, friendship, beauty, and so on and so on and so forth. And most of all, at the peak of this, the good, 'to agathon.'
- 3.52** The most famous central image of the Republic is one that you might have come across before. It's the so-called allegory of the cave. For a philosopher who did not have very much time for poets and playwrights, Plato is astonishingly poetic and literary in the way he makes his arguments. At the end of the Republic, he notoriously bans artists and poets and musicians from the ideal city-state. He wants to get rid of them. Why? Because they have a function similar to that of the sophists. They like to beguile citizens, but in a way that's independent of tracking truth. And yet he produces some of the most mesmerizing and memorable mini myths to convey his philosophical points that any philosopher has ever devised.
- 3.53** The famous one occurs, this most famous of them all occurs in Book 7, the Mount Everest of the Platonic dialogues, and very plausibly, Greek philosophy, ancient philosophy, indeed. And Socrates describes to his interlocutors a scene in which prisoners are shackled together at the bottom of a cave. And there's a fire which entrances them, and the flickering flames of the fire cast shadows on the back of the wall. And this has a—this entrances the prisoners. Until at one point, one of the prisoners manages to break the shackles, stand up, and walk up the path out of the cave and into the sunlight outside, which initially blinds him. His eyes adjust, and he returns down back into the cave.
- 3.54** What's going on there? To understand this little allegory, this mini myth, it will help for us to turn our attention to the previous book, Book 6, where Socrates advances this analogy between the sun and the good. Justice and sunlight. And what he tries to argue is that, just as the sun is the source of all light, the good is the source of all good things. What attracts Plato to this image of the sun is that the sun casts light, the sun illuminates, but is not itself illuminated by anything else. We might talk about the bright lights in this studio or about the light of a candle. We say, oh, those are lit, illuminating objects, objects with the power to illuminate. Oh, and the sun has the power to illuminate, too.
- 3.55** Now, we can feel that there's a difference. Something has gone wrong. The sun is not like other illuminating objects. The sun does not illuminate through borrowing light or energy from elsewhere, as is the case with all other sources of light borrowed from the

sun. Plato is pushing us to accept that there's a source of goodness, there's an ultimate source of goodness and justice that doesn't borrow its goodness or justice from anything else. Echoes of that dialogue, the Euthyphro, where Euthyphro says, 'Well, the good is just, or the holy is just what the gods tell us is the case.' Socrates ends that saying, no, it will—surely it's the case that it's something independent that the gods recognize. And here we start to see the development of that intuition.

3.56 So who is the prisoner who breaks the shackles? Well, we're invited to infer that it's Socrates himself, who breaks the shackles of ignorance amongst his fellow prisoners, his fellow citizens, and walks away from the fire. Remember, Heraclitus, remember the importance of fire for Heraclitus. That is the central, not just image, but he thinks it's the central element which explains and underwrites his metaphysics of flux and dynamism and constant change, where nothing is stable. It's almost as if the detail of the fire and the entrancing flames is a little dig at Heraclitus. It's a little dig at the philosophers who think, well, it's inspired in many ways by Parmenides, this idea that if you're trying to fix your philosophical vision on something as transient and immutable and unstable as the shadows cast by flickering flames on the back of the cave, then you're never going to get anywhere. You're condemned to a lifetime of conjecture, opinion, hazy belief, that's not rooted in anything at all.

3.57 The sun, by contrast, gives you, as it were, an absolute anchor, something that is fixed, bright. Yes, it may be obscured in different ways by clouds, by night, but it remains what it is. And the confusion and the obscurity, as it were, is our problem. The clouds are the clouds of philosophical confusion that can be dispelled only through Socratic dialectic, the Socratic give-and-take, the Socratic collaborative quest for truth. And once we've got a grasp on things that are illuminated by the sun, once we've adjusted our eyesight to the sunlight, we have knowledge. Bedrock knowledge, 'episteme', solid knowledge. Solidity that comes from the object of our knowledge, but also from the mode of access to that knowledge, and that mode of access is through, is Socratic dialectic. We've tested all of the different options, and we've reached this settled view. We can grasp the good in the way that we can grasp the truth that two plus two equals four.

3.58 And so we see in this famous high point of the Republic, the emergence of Plato's metaphysics. It's often referred to in the textbooks as his Theory of Forms. I haven't used that phrase deliberately because he doesn't. It's not really a theory. It's touched on, it's elaborated in different speeches that Socrates advances in the Phaedo and in the Republic, but it's never held out as a theory. And it's not clear that it's a, if it's not clear that it's a theory of forms, it's not clear that it's a theory of forms. The Greek word forms is 'edei', and there's a lot of debate as to what qualifies as a form and exactly what they are, and particularly how broad the scope is for including forms other than simply the form of the good. There's a great deal of debate about that.

- 3.59** But the key point to hold onto is Plato's insistence that there's a transcendent reality that is more real than the reality that is delivered to us through sense experience. That's crucial. He's not saying with Parmenides and the Eleatics that sense experience is illusory. It's tricks that elements might play on us through differently configured proportions of the four elements, through eros and eris, through attraction-repulsion, as Empedocles suggested. It's not completely illusory, but it is second-order. It is the realm of Becoming is the realm of belief, and it's the realm of Being that's the realm of knowledge, that grants, that yields certain knowledge.
- 3.60** And so in this single image, which is described in just a few paragraphs, we have, if you like, an extraordinary synthesis of the Ionian school and the Eleatic school. Both are given their due. You see a stress on the materiality, and the materiality that is discerned through sense experience, which is a characteristic of the Ionian school. You see the stress on the world of Being and solidity and transcendent reality beyond the world of sense experience that is characteristic of the Eleatic outlook. It's part of Plato's genius to be able to bring these two tectonic plates together.
- 3.61** It's easy to forget when we're thinking about Plato's metaphysics that the dialogue is about justice. First and foremost, it's about justice. It's about how to organize a city. How on earth are we getting in to talk about a theory of forms, or the nature of the good, or belief in opinion and knowledge? What has that got to do with a just city? We'll turn to that when we discuss Plato's political vision. We'll start to see how crucial is the analogy that he advances between a well-ordered soul that is attuned to justice and a well-ordered city is attuned to justice and the common good. Thanks for listening.

Lecture 4: Aristotle's Approach

At a glance — Aristotle's approach.

- 4.1 It's rare in the history of philosophy that a pupil outdoes his master. But in the relationship between Plato and one of his pupils, we see plausibly just that happen. Aristotle of Stagira will be the subject of this lecture. Notice, not Aristotle of Athens. Aristotle was from Hicksville, Macedonia, hillbilly country. Nothing that was worth anything came from Macedonia, it was thought by the Athenian elites, anyway. And Aristotle settles in Athens as a 'metoikos', a metic, that is to say, a resident alien. He's not ever given voting rights. He's never given full Athenian citizenship. For that, you needed an Athenian mom and an Athenian dad. And that distinction between citizen and alien was absolutely fundamental, both to Plato in the Republic, but also to Aristotle himself.
- 4.2 And yet we see emerging, as has happened at other points in history, emerging from the fringes of civilization, Macedonia, a genius who would transform civilization at its center, in Athens. Plato dies round about 347 BC, despondent, dejected, deeply grieved of the consequences of democracy and the sophistic rhetoric that, in his view, led Athens to catastrophe, horrified that a man as wise as Socrates, the wisest man he believed who had ever lived, should be put to death by this regime. We see in one of the last dialogues of Plato, the Laws, another attempt to devise a great political utopia, but a much harsher, much more authoritarian one than we see in the middle dialogue in the Republic.
- 4.3 And so he dies in 347. By this point, Athens is almost a backwater. And that hillbilly country that I referred to, Macedonia, was about to unleash on the world a geopolitical transformation, the likes of which had never been witnessed before. Through the figure of Alexander the Great, the son of Philip II of Macedon. Alexander the Great, born around about 356, is dead by 323. But at that point, he has conquered the Persian Empire. He dominates the whole of the Peloponnese and Attica, and all of the Middle East, stretching right across Iran to Afghanistan and to India, and sweeps back right across Egypt, founding the city of Alexandria, and he dies when he's still in his 20s, in effect, or early 30s. He's dead in 323.
- 4.4 It turns out that his master was Aristotle. You can see, in a weird way, Alexander the Great is an intellectual grandson of Plato himself. He's taught by Aristotle. He's tutored by Aristotle. He sends Aristotle back interesting bits and pieces that he comes across in his enormous conquests. And partly as a result of his association with Alexander, Aristotle is held in great suspicion by the Athenians, and he's sent into exile on the island of Euboea, modern-day Evia, and he dies in 322.
- 4.5 Aristotle's greatness can be captured, is nicely illustrated, by the fact that in the Middle Ages, when he is rediscovered halfway through the 12th century, he's referred to

simply as 'Philosophus', the Philosopher, capital P. There is no one who can really approach him in the minds of the great Latin scholastics of the 12th-century Renaissance. Aquinas, the great Thomas Aquinas, 1224 to 1274 in the 13th century, writes many commentaries on Aristotle's work, and if you like, baptizes Aristotle. Vast swaths of Catholic metaphysics, Catholic philosophy, have Aristotle's fingerprints all over them as a result of his colossal impact on Thomas Aquinas. For Dante, Aristotle was 'il maestro di color che sanno,' the master of all those who know.

- 4.6 For reasons that are still unclear, Aristotle leaves the Academy, which Plato had founded in a grove, an olive grove, outside Athens, consecrated to the hero Academos, and moves off to found a new school in the wolf grove. The Greek for wolf is 'lukos', and this wolf grove is called the 'lykeion', or in English, the lyceum. We have, in the foundation of the Academy, in the foundation of the Lyceum, as it were, the first institutional expression of higher learning of philosophy that we know of. Education for an Athenian in those days was nothing more than a bit of poetry, a bit of rhetoric, and lots of sport. Plato and Aristotle, between them, found institutions that stand in clear continuity with the modern university.
- 4.7 Indeed, the Academy, Plato's Academy, continues until 529 AD, nearly a millennium. It's closed by the Emperor Justinian in 529, the same year that St. Benedict opens his monastery in the foothills of Monte Cassino. It's a wonderful hinge year, that 529, the end of pagan learning and the beginning of a new monastic form of learning. But a new monastic form of learning that prized itself on the preservation of pagan learning. And we have many of the texts of Plato, and of Aristotle, and others, in part because of the great monastic tradition. So Plato, at his death, bequeaths to the world, not just dialogues, but also his finest pupil in Aristotle.
- 4.8 It's difficult to overstate the range of Aristotle's achievement. He wasn't just a brilliant physicist, and by physicist here, recall what 'physis' means in Greek, 'nature.' He wasn't just a great student of nature. He's the first physicist. That is to say, he's the first person to set down a work of physics. It's just called *The Physics*. Physics is called physics because Aristotle called it physics, 'ta physika', those things that are to do with nature, 'ta physika.' He wrote another astonishing text, which baffled the librarians of Alexandria about 200 years later. It seemed like physics, but it wasn't quite physics. It was about the conditions of the possibility of physics, that which went deeper than physics. So the librarians said, well, let's just put this treatise next to the physics, after the physics, to the right. 'Meta ta physika', after the physics.
- 4.9 And it's from that librarians' decision that we get the term metaphysics, which we talked about in the first two lectures. The way I described it, you might think that it would be better to call it trans-physics. That is to say, that which transcends nature, transcends the physical realm. But it's called metaphysics, that which is after, but also somehow before and prior to, providing the enabling conditions for the study of nature. Aristotle is the first to set down something akin to what we'd recognize as

biological treatises, *De Generatione Animalium*, on the generation of animals. He's the first person to set out a study of botany, plants. He's the first person to study the heavens, meteorology, in the *De Caelo*. He writes the first formal treatise of psychology, the *De Anima*, on the soul.

- 4.10** A lot of his works, by the way, have Latin titles, which are vestiges of the Latin rediscovery of Aristotle in the 12th century, which turbocharges Western civilization in many ways, in even more significant ways than the Enlightenment would 400 years later. It's a good argument to be made that the true Enlightenment, the true European Enlightenment, begins not in the 17th century, but the 12th, through the rediscovery and the retranslation, the translation of Aristotle into Latin.
- 4.11** He's the first person to write anything that we would—anything that had resembled literary criticism in that period. The *Poetics*. What are we talking about when we're saying that we enjoyed that play? Or that's good drama, that's a good poem? He leaves us the first treatise on rhetoric. The first person to try to systematize speech-making. What makes a good speech? What is the purpose of rhetoric? Aristotle gives us the first treatise on the soul, the first work of psychology, the *De Anima*. We'll talk about that more in greater detail later. And he's the first person to set out a work of political theory, in the *Politics*. We'll talk more about that in a bit, too.
- 4.12** He's the first person to write a work of ethics, moral philosophy. '*Ta Ethika*.' He gives us the word that we now use, the word ethic, '*ta ethika*', those things that are to do with '*ethos*', character. And indeed, most of his writings on ethics are to do with what makes, what forges good character, virtuous character. Aristotle is the first thinker to systematize logic—the *Prior Analytics* and the *Posterior Analytics*. He's the first person to start trying to work out a theory of the laws of thought, the laws of thought, how we reason, how conclusions flow from premises, and different forms that logic can take, different forms that a logical argument can take. He leaves us with a work described simply as the *Categories*, in which he sets out a taxonomy, a shopping list of ultimate reality, all the different categories that are being—all the different modes of being that there are.
- 4.13** You get the idea. It'll be impossible to cover all of those different facets of his genius. So I'm going to attempt in this lecture just to distill the most salient points. And there's no better place to start, really, than looking at Aristotle's understanding of being, and substance in particular. Substance, if you like, is the jewel in the crown of Aristotle's metaphysics. What do we mean by substance? What does he mean by substance? Well, the notion emerges from this fundamental distinction between things and ways that things are. Aristotle says there are things in the world, just things, substances, bearers of properties. We say of those things, we characterize those things in particular ways. The modes in which something can be characterized are the accidents or the properties.

- 4.14 We've got this distinction between substance, a thing, which bears properties, which is a particular way. The cake is brown, substance, property. Substance, cake; brown, property. And he introduces a second distinction. He says there's a primary substance, that cake, this person, and then there's a secondary substance. And the secondary substance is the broader classification that something exists within. This cake, cakes. Being a cake, that class of things which we can say exists, each of which exists as a cake. Now, that's not a particularly helpful example because a cake is an example of an artifact for Aristotle, things that we make. Aristotle is a lot more interested in naturally occurring substances. What is a naturally occurring substance?
- 4.15 For Aristotle, secondary substance was another way of talking about what philosophers today called a natural kind. A lot of philosophers don't believe there's any such thing as a natural kind. Plato, at one point in his dialogues, has a character talk about whether or not it's possible to carve nature at its joints. Can you carve nature at its joints? That is to say, can you carve up reality into certain objective categories, objective classes of things? Now, we think we can do this with species and genera and so on. But in fact, there's a lot of debate among philosophers of biology as to whether or not the way we classify species is purely conventional. That to say, it's our human way of imposing a kind of schematic order on the animal kingdom, or whether there are objective distinctions between species at all that's wired into the world, that we don't invent, but discover.
- 4.16 That's a huge debate still, and I would say the majority view among philosophers of science today is to reject Aristotle's claim that there are natural kinds, and to say that we do indeed project and discover classifications in nature, rather than tracking them and discerning them. We project and invent; we don't discover. But Aristotle thought you could, and he set about working out what were classes of things, what could qualify as a natural kind. And what he develops is the idea that what makes something, what qualifies something for membership in a natural kind is whether it has a set of necessary and sufficient properties, that make up what he calls its 'ousia', its essence. So the essence of a thing is what qualifies it for membership in a kind, in a particular natural category.
- 4.17 And this is a doctrine of metaphysical essentialism, the way that something is, that in virtue of which it is what it is. There's a lot of talk today in the popular press and in academic journals about this notion of essentialism. People get very worried about it. This idea that there's some fixed way for a human being to be is an affront to the liberal outlook of modernity. It's an affront to, it cuts against the grain of Enlightenment individualism. It cuts against the grain of the idea that we can be whatever we want to be, and we shouldn't be shackled by some metaphysical doctrine. We see this in particular in the transhumanist movement. The transhumanist movement is predicated on the idea that our human essence can be escaped. There is no kind of thing that a human being has to be. It's a kind of Disney metaphysics.

- 4.18 To say that something is essentially something, that X is essentially X, that human beings are essentially human, still actually gives a lot more leeway than one might think. It's very plausibly an essential property of human beings that a human being has 32 teeth. This is a plausible candidate for a biological condition that would make it onto the table of what is essentially human. It is of the essence of human beings, that a human being has 32 teeth. It is normal, normative. And we can use the word normative because it's anchored in this notion of essence. It's not just random. It's not just a statistical distribution. No, it's a fixed property.
- 4.19 But of course, if Fred loses a tooth, he doesn't cease to be a human being. But we can say, Fred is a defective human being. We say, Fred is a defective human being with respect to not having a full complement of teeth. And Fred should agree. I mean, he's going to go to the dentist or something. I mean, he'll be annoyed. It's not a moral judgment on Fred. It is normal for human beings to have two legs. It doesn't mean a war veteran who loses a leg ceases to be a human being. Aristotle's claim is that there are certain normative ways for natural organisms to be.
- 4.20 And the essence of a thing is anchored in its form, its 'morphe'. Every natural organism has a form, its essence, in effect, which it has in virtue of being the kind a thing that it is, and being a member of the natural kind that it is. One of the points that Aristotle departs from Plato is his sense that Plato is too addicted to the world of Being and stability, and that the Platonic heaven of forms doesn't explain with sufficient power the world of Becoming. Things are changing the whole time. Aristotle is a great student of change in the natural world, of the weather, of animals, of plants, of human beings. And he doesn't think that having these fixed forms up in Plato's heaven in the sunlight outside the cave adequately explains how these changes occur.
- 4.21 He thinks we need better reasons for change. We need 'aitia', reasons, explanations, causes. There are things we need to, we need to invoke an appeal to reasons for change. And so he develops, in the Physics, his treatise the Physics, a very granular conception of how change occurs, much more fine-grained than we're used to thinking about today. Today, certainly since the Enlightenment, which really defined itself by repudiating Aristotelian science and Aristotelian philosophy, since then, we really think of change purely in terms of what's called efficient causation. Production, just cause, bang, and effect, bringing about a physical effect. And this change, as it were, this transition in Western thought, airbrushed out three other 'aitia', three other causal principles that Aristotle thought were non-negotiable.
- 4.22 If we take the example of a statue, this is the textbook example. It's not the best example because, again, it's an artifact, like the cake. And this is much more for Aristotle a theory about naturally occurring substances. But it's easy for us to get a sense of what these four different causes are by reference to a human analogy. Take a statue. Aristotle would say, of our current way of thinking about causation, that all we're interested in is, how did the factory make this statue? What were the productive

processes involved in producing this lump of marble? And Aristotle says that's just manifestly, would say, that's manifestly inadequate.

4.23 First of all, it's not a lump of marble. It's a statue. It's a statue of something. And even if we had a perfect description, an exhaustive description of what's going on in the productive processes in the factory, that's not going to make any reference necessarily to the fact that, the kind of stuff that it is. So he says we need a material cause. We need a material explanation. What kind of stuff is it? Answer: marble. That's the matter. That's the stuff. The material cause is the stuff. You can't have a factory process without the stuff. So Aristotle says, one explanation is, that's got to factor in, is the marble, the matter.

4.24 And then he says, the factory process, the efficient causation, the productive process, isn't just random. This lump of marble doesn't just arrive at the factory, and then this statue of David or Daphne just pops out. No, it's a guided, sophisticated process. Why do we get a statue rather than just a different lump of marble, or the same lump? Aristotle says because there's a blueprint, there's a map, there's a vision, even if it's just in the mind of the sculptor, of what this lump of marble should look like. There's a form that this lump of marble must take to be a statue. That's the difference between the lump and the statue of David. It's a pretty big difference. And Aristotle says, we can't leave it out. There's a formal cause. There's a form we've got to appeal to. There's a blueprint in the mind of Michelangelo or Bernini. Probably a sketch on the wall of the factory, just so they know what they're doing.

4.25 So there are at least three. There's the material cause, there's the stuff, there's the form that the stuff must take. Then there's the actual hammering, the efficient process, the actual process in the factory. He says that's important, too. But Aristotle says, we still left out the fourth and most important explanation, the fourth and most important cause. Because up until now, we still haven't answered the question with respect to the statue. "Why?" Why has this process occurred at all? Why bring the marble from the quarry to the factory? Why spend time working out what form the marble is going to take? And why pay all these people to hammer the lump of marble into a beautiful statue?

4.26 Aristotle says, I mean, wouldn't an explanation of this statue refer to why on earth there's a statue here in the first place? Why this whole process started? It seems obvious. There must, says Aristotle, be a final cause. There must be an overarching purpose to this whole process. Maybe the sculptor needed the money. Maybe the sculptor just really liked the story of David. Maybe he wanted to impress Julius II. Might be multiple reasons. But those reasons are the fundamental ones. Those are the reasons why there is any statue at all, why there is a material cause, why there is a formal cause, and why there's an efficient cause, there's a final cause. So there we go. Those are the four causes—material, formal, efficient, and final.

- 4.27 And Aristotle insists that we must think of every naturally occurring substance through these four prisms. There is a purpose to every acorn. It is the final end, or telos, of every acorn. It's the vocation of every acorn to be an oak tree. The oak tree is contained within the acorn, you might say, in potentiality, in potency. And the acorn is, through an actualizing principle, it emerges into being an oak tree, all other things being equal. In other words, Aristotle offers a teleological account of nature. Nature is teeming with purpose and ends and goals. They're not conscious, intentional goals, but they are nevertheless directions of generation, directions of growth. There's a direction to change. It's not random.
- 4.28 And Aristotle insists that, in fact, the entire, all of natural reality is itself oriented towards a final end, a purpose, or a yearning for something ultimate that is what accounts for the motion of the heavens. And he calls that, in Book 12 of the *Metaphysics*, God, or that which is not moved, but it moves everything else, the unmoved mover, which is a separate independent substance that is entirely self-sufficient. It's not natural in the sense that it's not material. It's pure thought, thought thinking itself. 'Nous noesis noeseos.' Thought thinking itself. A kind of cosmic narcissist that all reality yearns for.
- 4.29 And this is 'l'amor che muove il sole e l'altre stelle,' as Dante puts it. The love, the desire that drives the sun, that moves the sun and the other stars. And so you've got this extraordinary vision. Remember our old friend Mr. Mind, from lecture two? Remember Anaxagoras? And you remember Aristotle's rather sharp comments that, although he was better than the babblers who came before him, actually, and Socrates says this in the *Phaedo*, he was disappointed. He was excited initially to discover Anaxagoras, and then just disappointed that with this amazing insight, he didn't press it into the service of a grander explanation. He still just reverted to a kind of atheistic materialism. Even though mind was part of his framework, just didn't put it to good use. Well, Aristotle puts it to good use. For Aristotle, cosmic mind, thought, is the organizing and animating horizon of the entirety of the natural world.
- 4.30 I mentioned in the last lecture that Plato, most famously in the *Phaedo*, advances four arguments for the immortality of the soul, four arguments in support of the claim that biological death is not death, that we are more than our bodies, we are more than our brains. Aristotle, to some extent, Aristotle accepts this. He does accept it, but he thinks it's too quick. And he thinks that Plato doesn't make enough of how integrated we are into our bodies, our material beings, as it were.
- 4.31 He doesn't think that we're just souls who are trapped in a body, waiting for the departure lounge into the next life or the next body. He thinks that our soul is in fact to our body as the form of the statue is to the lump of marble. That our soul is as impossible to separate from our bodies, from our biological being. Our psychological being is as impossible to separate from our biological being as it would be impossible to

separate the form, the animating blueprint of David, from that lump of marble. Take away the form, and you've got a lump of marble. That's it.

- 4.32 And so Aristotle is characterized, his thought is—central to his thought is the insistence that we are animals. We are biological organisms. We are members of the animal kingdom. His whole philosophy, you might say, is a bottom-up philosophy. Looking, unlike Thales, at the ground in front of him and works his way up. He starts from the a posteriori, from the empirical. The a posteriori is knowledge we get after we've got up off our posteriors in the armchair and where it's starting to inspect the world, whereas Plato is more convinced by the purity of a priori abstract armchair reasoning.
- 4.33 And Raphael captures this beautifully in the famous School of Athens painting. Plato is looking up, Aristotle to his left is looking down. And you've got a moody Heraclitus and dreamy Parmenides. And it's, go and have a look at the School of Athens once after you've listened to these lectures, and you can see our cast of characters populates that astonishing painting. So it's a bottom-up metaphysics, and it's a bottom-up account of our place in the world. And he argues in his short but brilliant treatise, the *De Anima*, On the Soul, that in fact soul is everywhere. Ensoulment is a condition of all organic life.
- 4.34 All plant life has a nutritive soul. It has a vegetative soul. That is to say, vegetation is alive. Plants are alive. This is what sets them apart from just rocks, inert stuff. We've got to account for this principle of life. OK, plants don't reason. They're not intelligent, but they're intelligent enough to feed themselves. The sun, the sunflower is intelligent enough to tilt, as it were, towards the sunshine. That's a form of ensoulment for Aristotle, nutritive soul. And then he says, what sets the animal kingdom apart from the plant kingdom is that the animal kingdom, in addition to the nutritive soul, also, all members of the animal kingdom have a sensory soul, perceptual faculties. All animals have sensory faculties in a way that plants do not, in addition to the nutritive soul.
- 4.35 And finally, he comes to the distinction between human beings and the rest of the animal kingdom. We're still in the animal kingdom, but what sets us apart within the animal kingdom is that, in addition to a nutritive soul and a sensory soul, in addition to our powers to feed ourselves, to understand the need instinctively for nutrition, in addition to our sensory capacities, we have the power of reason. Human beings, says Aristotle, are driven by the desire to understand the world. This is a very unusual feature of the animal species. We're the only kinds of creature that will turn up to a studio to listen to a philosophy lecture. This is strange behavior. This is abnormal behavior for members of the animal kingdom.
- 4.36 We have a rational soul, a 'logistikon', a capacity, a cognitive capacity. And that's what sets us apart. We have a rational soul. And that is part of our essence. It's part of the form that we have. It's part of what we are.
- 4.37 At this point, all the building blocks are in place for us to move into moral philosophy and to start thinking about ethics. In the first book of Aristotle's greatest work in moral

philosophy, and arguably, the greatest work in moral philosophy ever written, the Nicomachean Ethics, Aristotle says, we can't answer the question, 'What ought I to do? What is the good life? What is the life well-lived?' If we haven't got any understanding of what we are, of who we are, that question, he insists, must be upstream of any kind of question relating to what we ought to do. What we ought to do must flow from the answer we give to 'what kind of beings are we?'

- 4.38 We can say of the acorn that gets eaten by a pig and doesn't turn into an oak tree, it's failed to flourish. It's not reached its proper end. Aristotle says we're not so different from acorns. We are natural organisms. We, too, have purposes. And once we can work out what that end is, that ultimate state of flourishing, as it were, our oak tree, then, only then can we start to answer the question, 'What ought we to do to attain our oak tree?' Aristotle thinks, once we've got that horizon sorted, we can then say of any human activity or any human decision, this is a good decision in as much as it catalyzes an approach towards our oak tree horizon, or this is going to tend to push us away.
- 4.39 And Aristotle thinks we've now got a really secure basis on which we can evaluate different judgments, different practices, different habits. It's clear, and it's rooted in our nature. It's not just up for grabs. It's not conventional. It's not decided by a vote in the Athenian Ecclesia or the Boule, or by some thuggish general or sophistic, sophist, educated tyrant. It applies to us as human beings. And so what he attempts to do in the Nicomachean Ethics is to insist that there is a final state towards which all human beings tend. And the word he uses to describe this final state of flourishing is 'euodaimonia.'
- 4.40 It is irritating and unfortunately translated as happiness. The English word happiness is a useless and misleading word, and to be avoided at all costs in philosophy for all sorts of reasons. One of which it's a very recent word. It only emerges in the last, really, the last 400 years in anything like the sense that we understand it now, possibly a little bit less than that. Happiness originally simply means a state of coincidence, a state of random fortune. It's preserved, it's fossilized in the English phrase, 'That was a happy coincidence.' A happy coincidence. It's connected to the word, it emerges from the word 'to happen', or happenstance, just a sense of random occurring.
- 4.41 So happiness has within it a sense of fortuity, fortuitousness, of chance that would, for Aristotle, be intolerable. He doesn't think this is chance. He doesn't think this is random. This is all well worked out theory. He does believe in chance. He believes in 'tykhe', but that's not—he says, happiness can't possibly be our end state if it's got wired into it, at least in its etymological origins, this notion of randomness and chance. Of course, that's not what it means today, but nobody is quite sure what it means today. It's one of those polyvalent words whose semantic scope is in precisely inverse proportion to its definitional clarity.
- 4.42 You often get this in the public square. There's a phrase or a word that gathers momentum, precisely because nobody's quite sure what it means. This happens a lot.

Equality is one of those words. We're not quite sure what it means, but we know it's important, and it covers a lot of our moral intuitions, so we'll just stick with it. Diversity might be another one. Human rights. It's a phrase, again, it's very difficult to pin down quite what these terms mean, and it's very rare that there's any kind of consensus. But the consensus is hidden because of the currency, the widespread use.

4.43 Eudaimonia, in fact, means something like a state of natural flourishing, the flourishing that is appropriate to us in virtue of the kinds of beings that we are. That might take different forms. So, it might express itself in different trades, in different vocations, different forms of life. Aristotle isn't insisting that we all become one kind of thing. But he says that once we've attained that state of flourishing, we share with all other human beings who've also attained that state of flourishing a particular mode of exercising our rationality, exercising virtue through habituated practice in accordance with our reason. In accordance with our reason. In accordance with that which makes us distinctive, that which sets us apart from the rest of the animal kingdom.

4.44 And so the treatise, the Nicomachean Ethics, continues for 10, across 10 marvelous books, where he explores justice, friendship, temperance, where he addresses in Book 7 this fascinating question of whether or not moral failure is mental failure, as Socrates had insisted. Socrates insists in the Protagoras dialogue that no one does wrong willingly. That doing wrong is really—anyone who does wrong is doing it because they haven't properly understood the good. They haven't done enough philosophy. They haven't done enough dialectic. And because if, Socrates insists, if a human being properly understands, a human soul is properly in contact with the good, it's not possible for that knowledge to be out of sync with action. Theoretical reason has to go hand in hand with practical reason.

4.45 Aristotle thinks this is a crazy perspective, and in fact, he names Socrates in the dialogue when he's dismissing it. This can't be right. It can't be right. Surely, it can't be the case that professors of moral philosophy are better human beings, are morally better than those who haven't done any moral philosophy. I'm sure you'll be morally improved by this lecture on Aristotle, but it's not automatic. In fact, I think there was a study done a few years ago that suggests that ethics professors tended to hand their books back later and tended to get more library fines than the baseline. Maybe a greater confidence in thinking you understand what the good and the right is leads to a casual attitude to putting it into practice.

4.46 Aristotle argues that this can't be right because we're constantly confronted with scenarios every day where we know what's right, we know what's beneficial for us, we know what's not, and we will often go for what we know to be worse. We open up the fridge in the morning. We see the salad. We open up the freezer and we see the ice cream. We know which is better for us, and yet we reach for the ice cream. 'How is this possible?' asks Aristotle. 'How is it that we knowingly choose what is worse, the worse option, the option that is less conducive to our flourishing?' It's not just that Socrates is

wrong. I mean, he's obviously wrong because we do it the whole time. We're so familiar with that scenario. But it's still a puzzle for Aristotle, and he doesn't really—finds it difficult to grapple with it.

- 4.47 But he develops this notion that there is, within each of us, a source of that powerlessness, something he calls 'akrasia'. Remember that alpha privative is the negative, has a negative force. 'Krasia', from 'kratos', power. We have a sense of powerlessness, a weakness of will, that overrides our rationality, swallows it up, and that's what explains it. And part of seeking that ultimate horizon, practicing the virtues, is habituating ourselves to overcoming that 'akrasia', overcoming that weakness of will. And we do that, Aristotle thinks, through habit. We are what we repeatedly do. Aristotle doesn't say that, but that roughly summarizes the thought that we can form character. We can build up our character through practicing virtues over time.
- 4.48 Now, there's a lot of debate in contemporary literature among social psychologists as to whether this is actually true. There are some studies that suggest even the most high-minded people can be swayed by tiny little changes in the environmental conditions that make up a particular scenario of a particular moral quandary. And there have also been studies that suggest that Aristotle wasn't quite right to think that the virtues have a unity. If you become good at one virtue, then that means you're correspondingly better at another virtue, too. He thought that virtues were a package deal.
- 4.49 There are studies that suggest that children, one in the same class, will be happy to cheat on a spelling test, but will be very honest when it comes to a math test. The same people. There are studies that suggest that being a little bit late to a meeting will affect a class of seminarians who have just listened to a sermon on the Good Samaritan, will affect whether or not they will give money to a tramp waiting outside the lecture theater for the lecture that they're late for. If they're rushed, it's the same seminary. One group has to get there on time. It's told that they're running late, got to get there. They've all heard the sermon on the Good Samaritan. One class is getting there late. Another class has got a lot more time, and that class is much more generous to the tramp outside.
- 4.50 This is the so-called situationist critique of Aristotle's account of forming virtues through habit. It's a very lively debate, and it's still ongoing, and there are various counter-responses that a neo-Aristotelian could make to that. But just to flag that for you as an example of how persistent and perennial Aristotle's legacy is in moral philosophy, even today. It should be obvious to you by now that how beautifully systematic and integrated Aristotle's vision is, it's not like the dialogical patchwork of dinner party, drinking party conversations that we find in Plato. It's much more systematic.
- 4.51 What makes it all the more astonishing is that we have very little that Aristotle himself actually wrote. I told you about all those treatises. I mean, they are Aristotle's. But

most scholars believe that those treatises are really lecture notes. They're just scribbled by his students. The Greek is terrible, sometimes incomprehensible, sometimes very abbreviated, doesn't have any of the polish or cadence of Plato's prose. With Plato, there are very powerful reasons to identify as inauthentic certain those little bits of the Platonic corpus that we think are probably not him. One or two dialogues in some of Plato's letters we think are not authentic. We can tell that partly through stylometric analysis and through—and it's very clear from the distinctive character and pedigree of Plato's prose. It's not true of Aristotle. It's a mess.

4.52 Most of his treatises are, we get secondhand. Quite extraordinary, when you think of the transformation that he brings about, that it's mediated, refracted through his students. But it's systematic. There's an extraordinarily intricate architecture. And we've now reached the point where we can move into the final piece of the jigsaw, and that is politics and society. So we started from the most fundamental questions of metaphysics, the nature of substance and properties. We've moved through how substances change, through the four conceptions of change. We've shifted into thinking about the natural world and purposiveness, and then human beings as being an admittedly exceptional, but nevertheless intrinsic part of the natural world.

4.53 Talked about psychology and the soul, reason, what our own flourishing consists in, and the answer to that is ethics, and right and wrong, and pursuit of the good. And now we're ready to answer the question of how do good, flourishing individuals flourish in community? And this is the subject of the Politics, his work, the Politics. And in that work, Aristotle departs from Plato in his method. Doesn't offer a utopia. He doesn't sketch out an ideal city, which may just be theoretical or may, in fact, be a paradise that's attainable on Earth. It's never quite clear what Plato intends, whether it was just a thought experiment or whether it was actually something he thought could be put into effect.

4.54 Aristotle's approach is very different. He starts, as he always does, from the bottom and works his way up. Well, he says in the first book of the Politics, well, what kind of a thing are we? Before we ask, 'How do we get along together in society?', we again have to ask, upstream of that, 'What sort of beings are we?' You need to ask that question again. And he answers it by saying, well, we are 'politikon zoon.' Every human being is a 'politikon zoon.' An animal, zoon ; where we get zoos, zoo. And we are a 'politikon zoon.' We are a political, we are an animal fitted for the polis, not really political in our sense, but suited for the city-state, suited for political community, ordered, organized society. That belongs, that's the creature we are.

4.55 Biologically, we have an unusually long gestation period. We are a species where the offspring are dependent upon the maternal bond for much, much longer than elsewhere in the animal kingdom. We're dependent upon paternal protection for much longer than much of the rest of the animal kingdom. These are just facts for Aristotle, observable truths. And again, so this is a solid place to start theorizing. This is the kind

of creature we are. Then we can start to answer, how should we start to organize ourselves?

- 4.56 Well, given those biological facts about early life, human beings need a home, an 'oikos'. That is to say, there needs to be some unit, a basic political unit, in which the rearing of children and the protection of children is optimal. There needs, in fact, to be an institution, an institution of marriage between the biological parents, laying the optimal conditions for the rearing of offspring. So there needs to be a household. So that's the starting point, says Aristotle. But then a household is not enough. That household, in order to flourish, in order to be properly protected from externalities, negative externalities, needs dependence on other households.
- 4.57 And so we build up, says Aristotle, to a 'kome', a village, a cluster of these biological units, who will be enhanced, whose flourishing will be enhanced by the fact that they're connected together. They're looking out for each other in their small village, their small town. And this is necessary not just for protection, but for economic security. These permanent associations are valuable, and they're rooted, again, they're rooted in what we need as human beings. And not just in the cradle, but also just before the grave. We get older and weaker. We need protection almost as much as we did when we started out.
- 4.58 And Aristotle goes on to argue that even this is not enough. Villages need to bind together into a larger polis, a larger network, a larger structure. And so he begins to develop a theory of the polis. But what I want you to notice is that it's a naturalistic political theory. That is to say, it's starting from quite basic natural facts, quite plausible account of what kinds of beings we are. This is very, very different from the more utopian abstract political schemes that emerge at the end of the 18th century, notably in the French Revolution, and disastrously with the Bolshevik Revolution in the 20th century.
- 4.59 I should say, not with the American Revolution. I think in the American Revolution, you have something more recognizably Aristotelian. What does the Declaration of Independence begin with? It begins with certain claims about human beings. Life, liberty, the pursuit of—it was the pursuit of property originally, and that was swapped to the pursuit of happiness. If it was the pursuit of eudaimonia, Aristotle would have been happy with it. But notice how the logic of the Declaration works. It starts, saying, 'This is what we're like. This is the kind of creatures. We are creatures. We're dependent. We're fitted for these particular ends. And this is why governments are instituted among men.' It's a very Aristotelian impulse.
- 4.60 So that brings us to the end of our discussion of Aristotle, this extraordinary figure who, with Plato, transforms ancient thought and whose legacy is with us today. Thank you for listening.

- 4.61 So my question goes back to Socrates and Plato, and the distinction that Plato didn't really put his name in any of his works. And do you think that had anything to do with Socrates despising the sophists and that idea that we're not going to promote ourselves, that we're going to let our ideas stand out there for themselves, in order to be countercultural, almost as a nondescript rebuttal?
- 4.62 Yeah, it's a very good thought. There might be something to that. There's something self-effacing about Plato in lots of ways. There are other moments where I think he's giving us clues that he thinks he's by far and away the best. I mean, I noted the fact that the dialogue of the Phaedrus occurs underneath the Plato tree in the peak of the noonday sun. The sun, the image of total clarity and moral certain, knowledge, certainty of knowledge. And it's all happening under the Plato tree.
- 4.63 There's a wonderful moment at the end of the Symposium where everyone's passed out. They all just got so drunk, and there's only one of them still. It's just Socrates who's still clear as a bell, and the sun is coming up. Again, symbolic, and he's talking to the one person who's still not quite passed out, trying to convince this man that one and the same person could write both tragedy and comedy. I think it's quite clear that Plato believed that he could do both. He could be a brilliant tragedian, but he could also be a brilliant comedian. He could satirize the powers that be, and he could do it wittily, and he could lay out the greatest tragedy of them all in the life and teachings and death of Socrates.
- 4.64 But yes, there's something self-effacing about him. There's a shame that he feels, a sense of self-imposed exile with respect to Athens at the time. He's a scion of the Athenian elite. He's born into a very aristocratic family. Many of his relations were involved in the catastrophic decisions that led, that destroyed Athens. So that, from the golden age of the second half of the fifth century to the middle of the fourth century, it just becomes a backwater. And indeed, he goes off in a huff to Syracuse, in Sicily, and starts trying to train a tyrant's son in Sicily, thinking that that's the best way forward. Deeply skeptical of democracy, thinks that it descends into mob rule, and that you need really an aristocracy, where notions of what's good, 'ariston', are determined by philosophical enlightenment.
- 4.65 But yes, his name, he appears almost nowhere. In the Apology, he gives his apologies in the sense that his absence is noted and as an explanation given for his absence. In the Phaedo, he's recorded as being present, but he says nothing. But he's nowhere and everywhere. It is extraordinary, one of the extraordinary facts about the ancient world, that if you take some of its greatest figures, you take Homer, Socrates, Alexander the Great, and Jesus of Nazareth, between them, none of them wrote a word. Between them, we have not a single word. Nothing.
- 4.66 But for Socrates, we have actually four figures who write about him. There's Xenophon, who's a bit of a, slightly dumb Athenian general. We don't get much from that. Aristophanes, who mocks him mercilessly in the clouds. There's a guy called

Theophrastus who writes about him, but Plato is really our primary source for what he thinks. But Plato himself also curiously says nothing, is silent. That's an extraordinary fact, given their influence. There's a deep suspicion of the written word for Plato. He's not particularly proud to be the brilliant literary stylist that he is.

- 4.67 Much of the Phaedrus dialogue is about how suspicious one should be of the written word. It's a kind of suspicion we sometimes hear about AI today and computers. It's something, this new technology, where it's scary. There are various things that are scary about writing. You could crystallize falsehood in writing. To crystallize anything is to suggest that you've reached a conclusion about something. The whole notion of doing philosophy through dialogue is that it's open-ended. It never quite got to that final finishing point. And there's something that's disturbing to Plato about the written word, getting something trapped and caged through technology.
- 4.68 Hi, my question is about the difference in two words that you mentioned. You mentioned that Plato had the Theory of the Forms. I think you use the word 'eide', and Aristotle, obviously, had the essence and the being. I think the word you used was 'morphe.' Is there any difference between those two words, and does that tie into their philosophy as well?
- 4.69 Yes. I should have been clearer. 'Eidos' is the Greek singular, and 'eide' is the plural, which is the most, the word that Plato uses, I think, most commonly, to describe forms. Aristotle uses the word 'morphe' when he's talking about forms, the shape. We get from morphology or metamorphosis, a changing of shape. But he uses the word 'ousia' when he's talking about essence. And he uses the word 'hypostasis' when he's describing substance. Now, 'ousia' is also the word he uses, 'protos ousia' and 'deuteros ousia', when he's talking about primary substance, this particular human being, and secondary substance, 'deuteros ousia', human beings.
- 4.70 And so, a substance is not a form. A substance is a hylomorphic compound or composite of stuff, 'hyle', and 'morphe', hylomorphic. So, a substance, an 'ousia', has both form and matter. And so there is a difference there. The language of essence is really extrapolated from this, from the notion of form and substance. So that what makes Fred, a hominid, a human being, is that Fred is a hylomorphic compound, composite, as it were, whose form exhibits the essential properties that all members of the secondary substance hold. That's how it fits together.

Lecture 5: Stoicism

At a glance — Stoicism.

- 5.1** We're now entering in lecture five, the final strait of this course. Remember in the first two we looked at the Ionian school, then we looked at the Eleatic school, and then we dived into the 5th century, into the classical age, with the great figures of Socrates, his student Plato, and Plato's student Aristotle. We're now moving deeper into the 4th century. Plato dies in the 4th century. Aristotle is a 4th-century philosopher. And we're coming to the point where all sorts of interesting developments are occurring in the geopolitics of the Mediterranean and the wider world, that have an impact on how we're to understand these different emerging philosophical schools.
- 5.2** We noticed, in the discussion about Plato, how disquieting he found democracy, most of all Socrates's trial and execution at the hands of so-called democrats. In the 4th century, the cataclysmic event around which not only the 4th century turns, but also the subsequent history of the classical world, at least until the rise of Rome in the 2nd and 1st centuries BC, is Alexander the Great and his astonishing successes in military conquest. Sweeping right across through Greece into Persia, defeating the Persian empire, moving straight through Iran, modern-day Iran, and deep into the Indian subcontinent.
- 5.3** And that had an unsettling impact on thought, quite a positive impact, too. We talked in earlier lectures about this contrast between 'nomos' and 'physis', between convention, between the law of the city, and nature beyond the city. After Alexander's conquests, it became very difficult to think in those terms. There were just so many cities, so many different ways of organizing society, so many different cultures and languages and religions. And so we start to see something like a universalist impulse in the thought of this time. We'll come back to that in a while.
- 5.4** We see in the 4th century the emergence of the Academy, initially under Plato's leadership, until he dies in 347. And then we see the foundation, shortly after Plato's death, of the Lyceum, just about a kilometer away from the Academy, in the shadow of the Acropolis in Athens, by Aristotle. In other words, what we see is the emergence of a sort of stable schools of thought, schools of philosophy. You were a member of a school, you were a follower of this figure.
- 5.5** And we start to see the development of a sort of Platonic inheritance and an Aristotelian inheritance. So you became, you weren't so much a Platonist, you were, you were a member of the Academy, you were an academician. You weren't so much an Aristotelian, you were a peripatetic, 'peripateo' in Greece, in Greek. 'Peripatein' in Greek means to walk around, back and forth, to walk back and forth, which is what the Aristotelians like to do.

- 5.6 And some interesting figures begin to emerge, with ideas that become harder and harder to fit into either of these two schools. One of Socrates's followers was called Antisthenes, who had an enormous impact on a man called Diogenes. Diogenes of Sinope. Diogenes founded a distinct school or distinct tradition of philosophy known as Cynicism. Cynicism, as a school with, as a school of philosophy with a capital C, as it were, is rather different from our contemporary understanding of cynicism, but actually not miles away. It was a—one way of thinking about it is a sort of, as a radical expression of that Platonic suspicion of the sensory world, a radical suspicion of convention and ordinary rules and ordinary ways of doing things.
- 5.7 In fact, Diogenes is on record as not liking Plato's metaphysics at all, but instead, insisting that we need to break away from just the theoretical stuff. But there is still, within Diogenes' thought, this basic conformity to that Platonic, shall we say, subordination of the sensory and the world of Becoming and the world of change, to the world, the domain of Being and of transcendence. Plato once described Diogenes as 'Socrates gone mad.' And when Diogenes badgered Antisthenes to mentor him, Antisthenes simply ignored him and eventually had to beat him off with a stick. And Diogenes is reputed to have replied, 'Strike away, for you will find no wood hard enough to keep me away from you, so long as I think you've got something to say.' Kept following Antisthenes around.
- 5.8 And Diogenes' basic insight is that philosophy must affect the way I live in all respects. And it's a philosophy that doesn't just cultivate irrationality, quite the opposite. Diogenes is committed to reason and he's committed to the idea that the philosophical life, the good life, involves exercising reason in conformity with nature. Reason must be fitted to nature. It must go with the grain of nature. And he's reputed to have said that, 'To fortune, I oppose courage; to convention, nomos, I oppose nature, physis; and to passion, the emotions, I oppose reason.'
- 5.9 One of Diogenes' students was Crates of Thebes. And shortly after a shipwreck on his way to Athens, a man called Zeno of Citium arrives in Athens. This is 312 BC, and he goes to a bookshop and he starts reading Xenophon's *Memorabilia*. Xenophon is an Athenian general we referred to briefly in a previous lecture, one of our sources for Socrates. Not nearly as brilliant a mind as Plato, but we get some interest, an interesting different perspective on Socrates. And Zeno is gripped by this account of Socrates. And he asks the bookshop owner, 'Where can I find a man like this? Who is the Socrates of today?' And the bookshop owner points to Crates walking past. And Zeno starts to follow him, following, as it were, in this tradition of Cynicism, which is itself an inheritance of Socrates, as it were, through Socrates' pupil Antisthenes.
- 5.10 Zeno has a difficult relationship with Crates. Crates is reputed to have given him a pot of lentils to carry around, and he would hide this, the lentils, in his cloak. And Crates, on seeing this, smashed the gourd, smashed the flask, and it went all the way down his front. And Crates' point is, you've got to be willing to display, and outwardly display,

repudiation of convention, of politeness, of the way you ought to conduct yourself in the Agora, in the marketplace, where eating was banned, food was banned, or at least it was not good etiquette to eat in the Agora. Diogenes did it all the time. He also urinated in the Agora. And he would point at people with his middle finger, which was considered very rude indeed. It's a rejection of convention.

- 5.11** But this was all a little bit too much for Zeno. And although he takes up a lot of the principles that he learns from the Cynics, he starts to modify them a little bit. And in or around 300 BC, he himself founds a school in a colonnade on the edge of the Agora, again in the shadow of the Acropolis. The colonnade is, in Greek, is a 'stoa'. It was known as the 'stoa poikile', the painted colonnade. Beautiful, cool place to wander, walk up and down, and think. And so very quickly, the name of the school that Zeno founded came to be associated with the colonnade. 'It's that lot over there, under the colonnade.' The colonnade people, the 'stoa' people, the Stoics.
- 5.12** And Stoicism has been memorably described as cynicism for shy people, because it takes up a lot of the ideas, but without the dramatic rejection of social etiquette and norms and conventions. The school that Zeno founded would come to rival, and indeed even exceed and influence, the Platonic and Aristotelian schools. It became the third major, it would become the third major school in the Hellenic world. And indeed it would have a greater impact on Roman thought than even the Platonic and Aristotelian traditions.
- 5.13** What was Stoicism? Well, it was probably, first and foremost, a way of life, a way of understanding our place in the world. It was a humanist philosophy, you might say. It puts human beings, as it were, at the center of reality. The traditional division that makes up Stoicism is logic, physics, and ethics. Logic is far more than what we would understand by logic today. It would cover perception, it would cover language, rhetoric, and so on, the laws of thought and talk. Physics would cover the nature of matter, how to understand the cosmos, nature, the weather, ecology, and so on. Indeed, it would also include theology and the divine, because, as we'll see, Stoicism is a materialist philosophy. It has a materialist understanding of ultimate reality, of all reality, but makes room, intriguingly, for a divine source that runs like a thread through material reality.
- 5.14** Finally, the third part, ethics, the study of the good life, and by extension, the study of the good life lived in common. Political philosophy. You'll remember from our lecture on Plato that we dwelt on that image of the cave, the domain beyond in the sunlight outside, and then the flickering flames of the world of becoming, as it were, down deep in the cave. And as it were, the Forms are up out there in Plato's heaven in the sunlight. And one important philosophical function that that distinction played was to yield an answer to the problem of the one and the many. Or how can, how can multiple things also somehow share in a single thing?

- 5.15** Imagine a white cup and a white car. There must be something those two objects, different though they are in spatial location, temporal location, in shape, and so on and so forth, there is still something, intuitively, that they share in common, the color white. And part of what Plato is attempting to explain with his so-called Theory of Forms is to explain how those two objects share in a single universal. We can talk about, we can apply the word 'white' to those two objects. And it's not just accidental, it's not just a feature of our language. We're really picking out a single thing that those two distinct individual objects share. But what could that be? What could they have in common?
- 5.16** The idea is that there's a single, there is a, there is a Form, a universal, that these two objects, individual objects, exemplify. Now, Aristotle is not happy with this. It's not that he's not happy with the Forms. In fact, he loves the Forms. He loves the Forms so much that, as we saw in our Aristotle lecture, he brings them right down out of Plato's heaven, and wires them into every single naturally occurring object. Forms are actually much more inseparable than they are on Plato's view.
- 5.17** Aristotle's idea, though, is that Forms are particular to the kinds of substances and objects that they belong to. So we can say, of a knife, that it has the property of being sharp, and we can say it's a good knife because it's sharp. We don't say that a pen is good because it's sharp. We say that it's good because it can write well. Aristotle says that means there can't be some single good that both the knife and the pen share because what makes them good is the extent to which they conform to their nature, their own particular telos, the thing that they're meant to be.
- 5.18** With Stoicism, you see the emergence of something very different, a very different way of approaching this problem. For all their differences, Plato and Aristotle insist that regularities in the ways that things are are to be explained independently of us. We're discovering these regularities and explaining them, either by appealing to Forms and essences that are wired into the objects, or, as in Plato's case, by appealing to Forms that the different objects exemplify. They share it in common, they exemplify it at the individual level.
- 5.19** Stoicism rejects that basic posture. Stoicism explains the regularities in our sense experience, not through Forms or independently existing essences, but through concepts, from our own thinking, the concepts that we apply to sense experience, the filters of thought through which sense experience is mediated to us and through which experience is rendered intelligible, if you like. These thoughts, 'ennoemata', are intrinsic to us, as it were. And so the regularities are really a feature of our cognitive engagement with the world, not something that's a feature wired into the world as it is.
- 5.20** And so the Stoics developed something like the theory that's often called nominalism, or conceptualism, which emerges in the late 13th century and the 14th century in Europe among Latin, the Latin scholastics, William of Ockham in particular, and would then come to have enormous influence in early modern philosophy, and in the

Enlightenment, as it were, turned to the subject. You have here, as it were in Stoicism, a turn to the subject as the fundamental arbiter of reality. We're not searching for forms, we're not searching for explanations beyond us, for the regularities. We're imposing them. We're imposing our own filters onto sense experience.

- 5.21 The Stoics are impressed, however, with the order, the orderliness of the world and our capacity to order it through sense experience. So they don't cut themselves off from the world because they think that the world is organized according to a rational plan, a logos. And they are further committed to the idea that human beings have a kind of divine spark, a little slice of logos, a little slice of reason within us, through which the intelligibility of the world can be grasped.
- 5.22 And this logos is divine. It's referred to as 'theos', it's referred to as god. Even Zeus, they sometimes just call it Zeus. This is Zeus, God, nature. But these are all effectively becoming interchangeable, quite extraordinary. What you have is something like pantheism. It is, in effect, pantheism, the idea that all reality is coterminous with God, distinct from theism, certainly distinct from monotheism, which will insist on a radical ontological distinction between creator and creature. But it's a pantheism that's also committed to the idea that it's just matter. It's matter all the way down. Or rather, all beings are material beings.
- 5.23 They borrow Empedocles' four elements. What's hot is to be explained by fire. Hot things have an elemental fire in them. Cold things have elemental air in them. Wet things have elemental water in them, and dry things have elemental earth in them. But fire is the kind of, is the primary element, as it was to some degree for Empedocles and as it certainly was for Heraclitus. So you can see at this point, at the end of the 4th century, philosophy has become almost like a, it's like a banquet, all these different ideas that they're picking off the table, putting together into a kind of culinary collage.
- 5.24 They take from Plato's late dialogue, the Timaeus, the notion that the world is not created exactly, but invested with an intelligibility. In the Timaeus, you actually have a sort of creation narrative, referred to it in a previous lecture, a 'demiurgos', a sort of lieutenant deity who forges the world in accordance with Pythagorean patterns. Now that distinction has been collapsed, and as it were, intelligibility and reason is wired into nature itself. It's one and the same.
- 5.25 So you have a scala naturae, a ladder of nature, a ladder of being, which emerges. At the bottom, non-living material, stuff, rocks, minerals and so on. Then the world of 'physis', effectively plant life, then 'psuche', non-rational animals, but nevertheless had a soul. Remember, going back to Aristotle, all animals have souls. At least they have sensory souls. They have the capacity to perceive the world. That's a kind of ensoulment for Aristotle. Then, at the level of logos, you have human beings. Human beings have reason, and at the very top, you have God, perfect reason.

- 5.26 And the task of the Stoic was to teach its followers to conform themselves, to render familiar, through a process called 'oikeiosis', to render familiar the world in which they found themselves, to adapt to nature, to conform to nature. All of reality is a rational causal network. Fate, effectively. Stoicism is committed to fatalism, the way that, the idea that the world is structured in a particular way that is necessitated, that is basically causally determined. And we see in the Stoics, really, the earliest, the first theory, the first claim, that the first expression of determinism, the idea that the world is fixed, the course of nature is fixed, and by extension, our agency is fixed.
- 5.27 Now, this raises all sorts of questions and worries for the philosopher who is committed to the idea of the good and the right, notions that seem to carry within them the possibility of freedom. It's a deep intuition that I think we would probably all share to some extent, that the language of morality, the language of ethics, presupposes the capacity to act, to have acted otherwise, to have acted freely. If I praise somebody for doing something, it would be odd if they, if I knew at the same time that they'd been forced to do it. Similarly, if I blame somebody for something, it would be odd if I knew at the same time that they were doing it under duress.
- 5.28 'Ought,' says Immanuel Kant, many centuries later, 'implies can.' Ought implies can. If I say that I ought to do something, then I presuppose the capacity to do it, presuppose that I'm free to do it. That's a pretty plausible intuition. So what do we do with ethics, if we are embedded in a causally determined network? Well, we can't, it's not clear that we're free to do anything. Well, the Stoics had various solutions to this, and they developed a version of what is nowadays called compatibilism, the claim that it is possible that two things can be true, that the world is causally determined, and that I am nevertheless free to act within it.
- 5.29 And there are different ways of understanding this. As a theological compatibilism that St. Augustine develops much later, the worry there is, 'Look, if God is omniscient, then God knows what I'm going to have for breakfast tomorrow morning. But that means I have no choice. I'm not free to decide what I'm going to have for breakfast tomorrow morning. Porridge or toast? God knows which one I'm going to choose. How is it possible? I'm not free, not meaningfully free.' Augustine says, 'Not only does God's omniscience not undermine your freedom, it guarantees it. Because part of what God knows is what you're freely going to choose.' That's one of the things that he knows.
- 5.30 That's a version of compatibilism. Here's another way of thinking about it. Imagine you're in a room. There are two doors. There's a blue door on the left and a red door on the right. You've got 60 seconds to get out of the room or it's going to blow up. It's going to blow up in 60 seconds. You've got to get out. You can only make one choice, blue door or the red door. And you're not sure which one is going to get you out safely. You go for the red door. You quite like the color red. You have a good feeling about it. You freely choose it. You run for the red door. It opens, and you're out into a glorious meadow and you're free.

- 5.31 Unbeknownst to you, the blue door was locked. The only door you could have gone out was through, was the red door. You were determined, as it were, to go through the red door. You didn't have any freedom to do otherwise than go through the red door. But you still freely chose the red door. No one was forcing you to choose the red door. You could have gone for the, it might have been the case that you preferred the color blue. So that's a thought experiment that is intended to get us comfortable with the idea that determinism, a fully causally determined network, needn't exclude the possibility that we choose freely.
- 5.32 One test of causal determinism is a hypothetical. If the same situation were to occur over again, would you get the same outcome? And the Stoics said, yes, you would, because it's all determined. Would have been the same point in the network, and what would have changed? It's predictable. But that doesn't undermine my agency, doesn't undermine my free agency, because part of the causally determined network is my character, my thought patterns, my emotions, my genetic inheritance. Everything is wired into that. And as it were, that's part of the network. Personality, dispositions, awareness, and so on.
- 5.33 But this doctrine brings with it, or claims to bring with it, a form of 'therapeia', a form of therapy or cure for the soul. Because within this framework, chance disappears. There are no more accidents. Reason is primary, and emotions and emotions, and emotions as the source of suffering are characterized as false valuations of the way the world is. Reason must be pure, reason is unsullied, should be unsullied by the emotions, by the non-cognitive dimensions of our, of our personality. And the more we cultivate reason, the more we fit into, the more we harmonize ourselves with nature. And whatever nature has in store for us, whether it's good or whether it's bad, we might react, have positive emotions or negative emotions, in response to how we find ourselves in the world. But those are to be repudiated because we're supposed to understand through our reason that we are part of this natural rational development of the world as a natural process.
- 5.34 You'll remember from our lecture on Aristotle how important it was for him to have that organizing horizon of eudaimonia towards which we're supposed to cultivate our virtues as habits, exercising our reason and fulfilling, as it were, our essence. The Stoics adopt something quite similar to this notion, but the telos is somewhat different. The telos is conformity to the rational principle of the cosmos, of the universe. Not a particular essence, biological essence, that the acorn might have or that human beings might have. Stoics share with the Platonists the notion that we have within us a soul that is more than merely a natural feature of us, as a biological animal. It's a spark, it's a transcendent divine spark, a logos that allows us to tap into the rational principle that is driving an organizing nature.
- 5.35 And to that extent, it's a slightly less, you might say, slightly less naturalist or slightly less biological a conception of human nature than what we find in Aristotle. For the

Platonist, the task of the ethical life was 'homoiosis theoi', an assimilation or a conformity to God, 'to theoi', to the divine. And the Stoics adopt something similar to that view, except they understood 'to theoi', God, divinity, to be nature. God and nature are coterminous within the Stoic, within the Stoic framework.

- 5.36** And this has interesting implications. One of the implications was a radical ethical universalism in Stoicism. Socrates is reputed to have said that he was a citizen, not of the polis, but of the world. Diogenes the Cynic is allegedly the first to have used the word 'kosmopolites'. I am a 'polites', a citizen, 'tou kosmo', of the universe, the world, the ordered —remember kosmos? The ordered, decorated, intelligible world. But it's really with the Stoics that we have the first notion that all, all human beings share in this logos, in this divine spark.
- 5.37** And I don't think it's an exaggeration to say, therefore, that in Stoic philosophy, we find the invention of the human. The invention of human beings. Once upon a time, there were no human beings. Even when there were many civilizations around, the thought that there was some category of human beings distinct from your membership of your particular society or city-state was very much on the fringes. It's not the way they thought. A notion of human rights would be completely unintelligible. No, you're an Athenian, you're a Corinthian, you're a Theban. There are barbarians. They are the people who go 'baba', who speak rhubarb. They're the foreigners, the other.
- 5.38** Are they human beings? Well, no, they're barbarians. They're barbarians. Maybe they're Persian barbarians, there are Babylonian barbarians, there are Egyptian barbarians, but they're not Greek speakers. They worship different gods and—yes, but aren't you all in the same glorious human family? What are you talking about? This is not a thought that they would cope with. Maybe they could think of it in the abstract. There is the word in Greek, 'anthropos', which means a human being. It means a member of the human species. But that was normally applied in a biological sense or in a purely sort of theoretical sense, certainly not in an ethical or political sense.
- 5.39** But with the Stoics, you have the beginning of this notion that, no, because every human being has within him or her this divine logos, this spark, that instills within them a worth, like a moral worth. And so, as I said, I don't think it's an exaggeration to say that we're beginning to see here that the birth of humanity, the beginnings of this notion, the beginning of the category, as it were, the first emergence of the category of human beings, of cosmopolitanism, as it comes to be called later.
- 5.40** Even if Stoicism remains, throughout its history, deep into the 2nd century A.D., 3rd century A.D., it remains an aristocratic philosophy. It's really, it's really a philosophy for the wealthy and the well-to-do. It's never quite a philosophy that trickles down to the street in a way that, say, Christianity does very fast in the first century. It's easy to manage the vicissitudes of life if you've got a large household with many slaves and lots of wealth. You can be detached. You can detach yourself very easily.

- 5.41 The crucial point to note, though, is that Stoicism is primarily a philosophy of life. It's philosophy as a way of life. Now, that's not to say that they don't have sophisticated theoretical accounts of nature. They do. But at the center of the framework are human beings exercising their reason, controlling their emotion, recognizing that there's a providential ordering to all of nature, that this is the best kind of providential ordering. This is the best world. There isn't a better one. Everything's going to happen, no matter what. So there couldn't be a better one and there couldn't be a worse one. And that is intended to instill a kind of psychological resilience to the apparent messiness of human experience and human fortune, and a kind of indifference to it, a detachment from it.
- 5.42 And this has enormous appeal to the Roman mind, when Stoicism trickles over to Rome. This is a moment that we can point to with some accuracy, because, in 155 BC, Athens got into a bit of trouble. It attacked Oropos, and the Romans, who were in charge by that point—we've really got the rise of the Roman Republic and the dominance of the Roman Republic right across the Mediterranean world, in halfway through the 2nd century BC. Athens, Rome decided to fine Athens 500 talents, an enormous amount of money. A talent, one talent is roughly what would be, roughly speaking, what one person could earn, one quite wealthy person could earn in a year. 500 talents is not a trivial sum.
- 5.43 And so Athens decided to send the rockstars of its day to Rome to plead for a reduction in the fine. And they sent the heads of the three schools, the head of the Academy, Plato's Academy, of the peripatetics, of Aristotle's Lyceum. And third, they sent Diogenes of Babylon, who was at that point the head of the Stoic school. And they did a pretty good job. They made brilliant speeches. And after their short visit, the Senate agreed to reduce the fine from 500 talents to 100 talents. But they were particularly impressed by Diogenes, the Stoic. They were impressed by his moderation, his calm, his temperament. And that's as good a place as any to mark the beginning of the infusion of Stoicism and Stoic thought into Roman culture and into the intellectual life of republican Rome.
- 5.44 And it's taken up and spreads and disseminates faster than any version of Platonism or Aristotelianism. Crucial here would be the figure of Cicero, in the 1st century BC, and Seneca in the 1st century AD. Cicero and Seneca are not in the same league as Plato or Aristotle, but they are brilliant minds in their own way. Seneca is a brilliant playwright, Cicero a brilliant orator. They weren't philosophers at the level of Plato and Aristotle. They were practical men living in an intensely practical culture and living through a time particularly, well, in the 1st century BC with the collapse of the Roman Republic and complete chaos, the emergence of a dynastic empire slowly in the late 30s BC, but it's a world that's freighted with staggering success, the Roman Empire's sort of dominance in the 1st century BC, but also its internal collapse through the civil wars of the 40s and the 30s BC.

- 5.45 So it's a time of deep uncertainty and staggering shifts in human fortunes. And so you can imagine, and this is a little speculative, but what I want to suggest is that it's a time of tumult and so a time that's unusually receptive to the wisdom of the Stoics and to the psychological resilience that Stoicism urges its followers to inculcate. And Cicero is probably the finest exponent of that.
- 5.46 Seneca is excellent as well. Seneca, though he's living in the 1st century A.D. things have settled down a little bit, Seneca, Seneca's fortune, ill fortune is to end up as private tutor and counselor to the Emperor Nero, which starts OK, the first five years anyway, and, but very quickly descends into anarchy and chaos to a degree that had not really been witnessed before in Rome. And so Seneca's, Seneca's writings, particularly his essays and his letters, are a key source for late Stoicism. And they're a fascinating insight into a brilliant mind that is applying Stoic philosophy to extraordinary vicissitudes in his own, in his own fortunes.
- 5.47 The final figure I should, final two figures I will mention—one, Epictetus. Epictetus' Discourses are our primary source for late Stoicism. Well worth a read. Discourses, really, on the art of living. And finally, and perhaps surprisingly, an emperor, a philosopher emperor, Marcus Aurelius, who is emperor of Rome, 161 to 180 AD. Really, a period where we could say the Roman empire is at its absolute peak in terms of territorial expansion and prosperity. The decline begins almost as soon as Marcus Aurelius' tenure as emperor comes to an end.
- 5.48 And what we have is quite extraordinary. From Marcus Aurelius, we have a work of philosophy written in Koine Greek, effectively New Testament Greek, in 12 books known as the Meditations. And you can read the Meditations cover to cover without knowing who the author is. And if you were to guess what the author did for a living, or when he wasn't doing philosophy, you would never suspect that this was the most powerful human being in the world and, arguably, given Rome, that this is the peak of the Roman Empire, arguably the most powerful man ever to have lived, most powerful human being ever to have lived.
- 5.49 And yet you read the Meditations, and there's nothing, and much of which were written on campaign in Pannonia. So he's fighting the Germans, he's organizing vast armies, incredibly complex logistics and so on. Very, very canny commander, also running an empire back home. But he's on campaign at the same time, and he's taking time every evening to write in a foreign language, in Greek, a set of philosophical reflections on his inner life and how to conduct yourself and how to deal with misfortune, how to deal with good fortune, 'treat them as imposters, one and the same,' as Kipling says in his famous poem.
- 5.50 It's a fascinating text. It's philosophically not particularly innovative. There's nothing really new in it. Passages, some passages, frankly, are quite tedious. But really it's, the miracle is that it was written at all, and the miracle that we, is that we've got it. We've got this extraordinary insight into the inner life of a Roman emperor. We're closer to

Marcus Aurelius' inner thought world than we are to almost any other figure in the ancient world because of the form that the treatise takes. *Meditations*, it's like an internal biography, a biography of the inner life.

- 5.51** We don't see anything like it until Augustine's confessions in the 390s, which is arguably the first autobiography ever written. And it's comparable in various ways with the *Meditations*. Augustine said, when asked whether, well, in the context of the relationship between Stoicism and Christianity, and there are certain parallels, Augustine says, 'I refute Stoicism in two words. *Jesus flavit.*' The shortest verse in the Bible. *Jesus wept.* For Augustine, Stoicism was far too rational. Stoicism extracted and reified and deified reason to the exclusion of emotion and of the passions.
- 5.52** And for Augustine, this was completely irreconcilable with the record that the New Testament gave him of the God-man. If God can weep, if God can get angry and turn over tables in the temple, then emotion is important and is not to be something that we should be detaching ourselves from. And yet reason is there, too. We talked in an earlier lecture about the role of *logos* in the New Testament, and particularly in those famous opening verses of St. John's Gospel. And we talked back then, I think, about whether or not there's Heraclitean echoes there, and I suggested probably not. But yes, in as much as Stoicism is a more plausible direct influence, and Stoicism is quite plausibly itself standing in relationship of influence with, is influenced by Heraclitus and Heraclitean ideas.
- 5.53** But it's very plausible, given the dominance of Stoicism across the Roman Empire and the Hellenistic world, that talk of the *logos* as a divine animating principle and source of intelligibility for all reality was common currency among the educated of their day, particularly in and around Ephesus, the location that scholars believe to be quite plausibly where John is writing, and the Johannine communities are beginning to emerge in the 70s, 80s, and 90s AD.
- 5.54** So there we have it. That's Stoicism. Of all of the different philosophies we've looked at so far, this is one you'll start to see popping up all over the place. On the Internet, in airports, everywhere. There is a cottage industry of neo-Stoic primers, some of them very popular indeed. Stoicism has influenced a number of thinkers, in particular Aaron Beck, who is the father of cognitive behavioral therapy, or CBT, which seems to me one of the very, very few forms of psychotherapy worth engaging in. That's just me. But those of you familiar with cognitive behavior therapy will know that we'll be able to see that the sort of Stoic tools are being used, particularly on the stress that this form of therapy puts on reasoning through your emotional responses to events. The stress that it puts on that classic Stoic idea that it's not events that disturb us, but our judgments about events.
- 5.55** And my view is that it's a great idea that Stoicism, it's great that Stoicism has had this revival, and I think it's perfectly possible to draw wisdom from it, provided we're aware of what's going on underneath the surface, the commitment to a metaphysical

framework, a causally determined network of events, a divine logos that is God, a cosmos that is burning up every so often for a process of 'ekpyrosis', pure rational fire, burning it up. And then it immediately, then it, as it were, reinvents itself, comes back into being again. We need to be aware of all of that, and we've got to be careful that we're not just picking bits off the banquet.

5.56 We can make use of what might help us. We'd have to be cautious, too, though, of a form of neo-Stoic therapy that invites us to shut down our emotions completely, as nothing more than a source of interference in reason. And there you might feel the pull of Augustine's refutation. Even if you don't sign up to his theology nor his Christianity, you might still recognize a power in Augustine's insight that to be emotional is to be human, and to try and just free ourselves of our emotions and focus purely on reason would make us not divine, as the Stoics believed, but as something less than fully human.

5.57 Thanks for listening.

Lecture 6: Epicureanism

At a glance — Epicureanism, the final lecture.

- 6.1** We come now to our final lecture. This final chapter will focus on another philosophy that lingers with us to this day. That's the philosophy of a man called Epicurus. Epicurus is born in Samos, island of Samos, the same birthplace as Pythagoras. But he could not have been more different in his philosophical outlook from Pythagoras. Remember, Pythagoras stresses the foundational role that number and mathematics plays in ordering the world, the role that it plays in explaining the patterns and orders that we find in the world.
- 6.2** Epicurus, who arrives in Athens round about the same time as Zeno, develops a philosophy that had been in the air already, the philosophy of Democritus and Leucippus, the philosophy of atomism. Atomism was the view that all reality is material and reducible to countlessly many indivisible units that were called atoms, based on the Greek 'temno' to cut, the alpha privative uncuttable, uncuttable unit. These were the building blocks of Epicurus' metaphysics. No spooky stuff, no number, no mysterious forces of repulsion and attraction, no mystical talk about Being. It's just stuff all the way down. Atoms organized by nothing at all, by 'tyche', chance, pure chance.
- 6.3** And this framework, if you like, provides for Epicurus a surprisingly wide range of answers to the human condition and the nature of experience, how we understand ethics and the good life, how we understand religion and the gods. Many of the philosophical approaches we've seen up until now are what you might call top-down. Come up with a scheme and then start to filter the world through scheme. Epicurus and the atomists, starting from the bottom, and they're not even building up very much. The atom, the atomic layer, is really all that there is, that atoms are configured in all sorts of, an endless variety of ways, but through chance.
- 6.4** There's no logos, there's no ordering principle. There are no gods, there are no divine superintendents, at least no divine superintendents that are still around anymore. This philosophy, this metaphysics, materialist metaphysics, would have an enormous influence, not only on Roman thought through the great Lucretius, a poet who writes a long poem in hexameters, dactylic hexameters, called the *De Rerum Natura*, on the Nature of Things, which is this extraordinary, the greatest philosophical poem ever written, extraordinary, extraordinarily powerful poetic expression of Epicurianism, and really our only complete source, if you like, for Epicurianism. We have virtually nothing from Epicurus himself. Very little indeed. And indeed, that poem of Lucretius was only rediscovered in the 15th century in a monastery library, so it didn't have the sort of influence that, say, Aristotle had on the 12th and 13th century renaissance of scholastic theology.

- 6.5 But the basic idea that the world is just made up of things, units, material units, is in many ways how a lot of philosophers today, in the Anglo-American tradition, understand ultimate reality, understand what reality is. And that's partly a feature of the staggering success of the natural sciences over the last 250 years. There is a persuasive power to the claim that, well, if philosophy is going to be anything at all, if it's going to be successful, it's going to need to borrow its success, as it were, from the natural sciences. It's got to align itself somehow with the natural sciences. Metaphysics used to be prior to physics, but now it's almost as if metaphysics is trying to catch up and shape itself to the findings of physics.
- 6.6 My own view is that that's confused. Metaphysics is metaphysics. And to say that all reality is atomic, or all of reality is made up of indivisible spatiotemporal points, is a metaphysical claim. It's not a finding of science. It's something that is prior to science. To claim otherwise would be a little like the scenario where a drunk is looking for his car keys under a street lamp, and when asked, 'Why are you only looking under here?', replies, 'This is where the light is. Why would I look anywhere else?' The person committed to the idea that all truths are scientific truths, because that's all that science shows us, I think is analogous to the drunk.
- 6.7 'There may be more things in heaven and earth,' Hamlet says to Horatio, 'than I dreamt of in your philosophy.' Still, the impact of the success of the natural sciences makes the metaphysical claim that underpins atomism a plausible one, or it gives it a certain plausibility and power that it did not have prior to, say, the 17th century. Prior to Thomas Hobbes, 1588 to 1679, probably the first philosopher of the early modern period who is a so-called corpuscularian, a corpuscularian. 'Corpuscul', literally in Latin, 'corpusculum', little body, a little corpus, a little body. So it's the Latin, the Latin for atom is 'corpusculum'. So the corpuscularians, Hobbes and his followers, partly in England, also in France, witnessed a recovery of Epicurus' atomism, itself borrowed, as I said, from Democritus and Leukcippus.
- 6.8 We see also the emergence of atomism in Islamic philosophical theology. If you've just got a world of atoms governed by chance, and if that's what seems to be most consistent with natural science, then this is threatening to monotheism, threatening to the claim that, no, the world cries out for explanation. It's not just chance. It's not just random. There's order and pattern here, and we need to explain this, this intelligibility. That's not just an Islamic or a Christian or a Jewish or an Abrahamic worry. We saw with Anaxagoras, remember Mr. Mind, that impulse? That no, there's something going on here that is like, mind-like, or it's purposive. It's not just random. We don't see randomness everywhere. We see order.
- 6.9 Even to talk about chaos and randomness presupposes language and thought and observation, which seems to presuppose that chaos is not fundamental. We think thought presupposes order. Thought would stop if it were not ordered and sequential. So we see it in Anaxagoras. We saw how Anaxagoras impresses Socrates in that

passage from the *Phaedo*. Anaxagoras, he started so well. Why did he end up with this weird atheistic materialism when he had the main ingredient there to put it all together? We see in Plato's *Timaeus*, do you remember the demiurge? Fitting with this weird creation story you see in Plato, Plato's dialogue? It has an enormous impact on Christian theology in the last quarter of the first millennium and deep into the 12th and 13th centuries. It's actually probably the only dialogue of Plato's that is around at that point.

- 6.10** So this notion that there's an orderliness in reality that needs to be explained by something that's outside the orderly reality that we're trying to explain, because if it were inside, you'd have a kind of metaphysical bootstrapping problem. Well, how does, nothing can create itself. You can't have anything that's a *causa sui*. You can't have anything that's a cause of itself. But because to bring something into existence, to bring about an effect, presupposes a distinct originating source of that effect. You can't be the cause of yourself because you're already around when the causing starts. What stands at the end of the causal process is already there at the beginning of the causal process.
- 6.11** So there is that insistence, that sense that, if the world is made up of corpuscles and atoms, indivisible units, it must still be structured in some way. The great Arabic philosopher Al-Ghazali claims it adds another theological layer to this and says, well, it's fine to have atomism. It's fine to have this Epicurean vision of an atomic metaphysical landscape. It's good that he's invoking chance rather than causal fizz between the atoms, like causal connections in the way, and everything is causally connected in the way that the Stoics had it.
- 6.12** Why does he like that? Because if there was causal fizz between the atoms, then there would be a rival source of order and causation to God. And divine causation is too big for any other kind of causation. God can't have rivals when it comes to ordering the world. And so Al-Ghazali says it's atoms all the way down. There's no causal connections between the atoms. We think there are. It looks like there are. We say that there are. We do science on the world, assuming that there are these causal connections, or we used to. But really, it's God holding everything together. God is the ultimate arranger of all the causal patterns and all causal connections between these atoms. And causal connections that we see are merely the occasions, the occasions for divine action. This doctrine comes to be known as occasionalism.
- 6.13** And it's taken up again in the 16th century by Malebranche, the French philosopher. This God as a puppeteer with all the atoms as his puppets, all the puppets as an arrangement of atoms. Then David Hume comes along and he says, 'Well, I like this landscape, but why do we need God? Why do we need the puppeteer? Let's just cut the puppet strings.' So we've got just a landscape of local matters of particular fact, and no necessary connections are allowed between them. It's just a mosaic of disconnected tiles.

- 6.14 And this theory was really the theory that subverted and defeated the theory inherited from the Aristotelian tradition, where form and matter are completely connected, and objects have powers of their own. The world is populated by substances with powers and dispositions. The corpuscularian, Epicurean, atomist philosophy takes all of these away and renders them inert. And this is still one of the big debates in contemporary Anglo-American metaphysics, debate between those who are committed to a world of pure, inert properties, units, versus those who are committed to the idea of there being substances with powers, over powers to bring about changes and effects in the world.
- 6.15 So that's the metaphysical backdrop. What, though, are the implications of this philosophy for human beings, for ordinary human beings? Because, in fact, Epicureanism, like Stoicism, is also, it also has a humanist impulse, a sense that, yes, metaphysics is important, but this is fundamentally a framework for understanding human agency, human reason, human emotion, our relationship with the divine, our relationship with the public square and political life. So what were those implications?
- 6.16 One thing to note is that Epicurus set up his school not in a colonnade on the edge of the Agora, not in an olive grove, just off the Agora, as Plato did with the Academy and Aristotle did with the Lyceum, but in a garden, a private enclosed garden, about a kilometer from the hub of political and civic life in Athens. And whether he intended it or not, that's a perfect metaphor for the Epicurean attitude to involvement in political life, which was, don't get involved. Withdraw. There's a kind of quietism, a political quietism, to the Epicurean outlook. All is randomness, all is chance. We don't have much effect on the world at all, and so we should stop concerning ourselves, making ourselves anxious, by thinking that we can do what we can't, in fact, do.
- 6.17 And so we need, says Epicurus, to cultivate a state of 'ataraxia', ataraxia. Literally, well, 'tarasso' means to, 'tarassein' means to confuse or to disturb, to throw into a state of, to unsettle. So ataraxia is a state of being at complete peace and ease and detachment, in a state of total freedom from confusion and worry and disquiet. And this is the, it's the primary focus of Epicureanism as a way of life.
- 6.18 In addition to urging withdrawal from the public square, Epicureanism also stresses the importance of a detachment from the divine, of a detachment from worries about what the gods might or might not do. There is a place for the gods in the Epicurean vision of reality, but the gods are not involved. This is, though it's anachronistic to use this word, they are deists. So they're committed to the existence of god, but they deny any influence or interaction between god and world. The gods, they don't really care anymore. They've disappeared.
- 6.19 And in fact, mystical experiences, religious experiences, superstitions, belief in the spooky, for the Epicureans, those beliefs are flatly inconsistent with the materialist metaphysic. It's all stuff, it's all matter. There aren't any ghosts, there aren't any angels, there's no spooky stuff at all. And this should help us. This relieves us of a great burden. It relieves us of the burden of religion and the economy, the strange economy of

religious sacrifice that characterizes the ancient world in particular, the Greco-Roman world in particular. Remember that the theology of the Greek world at this point is, well, complex and difficult to distill in a few sentences, but it made much of the absolute separation between immortal gods who enjoy a basically amoral existence—they can do what they want, and they live forever—and the mortal, powerless, dependent beings who are their playthings.

- 6.20** This is basically the great animating pathos and tension of the Iliad, and it's still lingering well into the 5th and 4th centuries BC, even though the currents of rationalism and demystification are coursing powerfully by that point. And we see, for example, in Herodotus, the logic of a kind of back-and-forth with the gods. It's the famous inscription on the temple of Apollo in Delphi. Well, there were two. 'Gnothi seauton.' Know thyself. And 'meden agan', nothing in excess. These two principles. Know thyself; nothing in excess.
- 6.21** And there's a lot of debate about what the first one means in particular. But the basic thought is central to Greek theology, which is, make sure you, mortals, don't ever get above yourselves. Don't overreach. Don't forget your place in this scheme. Do not provoke the 'phthonos ton theon.' Do not provoke the envy of the gods. Do not be, do not indulge in arrogance or 'hubris', hubris. Hubris will provoke the 'phthonos theon', the envy of the gods, and you'll be struck down. This will be your nemesis, your proper apportion, your proper, your just punishment for overreaching yourself, for not knowing yourself, not recognizing that is your mortality and your finitude, your place in the scheme, and for not recognizing that you should not act excessively. You'll be punished by the gods for that, and this could happen at any time.
- 6.22** Fortune is fickle. Empires come and go, city-states come and go. The ancient Greek mind was beset by a paranoia, a cosmic paranoia. They loved stories of sudden misfortunes, from being pulled down from greatness to catastrophe. Think of Oedipus in Sophocles' plays. Think of Agamemnon in the great opening play of Aeschylus' Oresteia. Think of Pentheus in Euripides' Bacchae, or Creon in Sophocles' Antigone, these great rulers who are just struck down. The Oracle at Delphi was famously consulted by the wealthiest man in the world, Croesus of Lydia. And Croesus is eyeing up the emerging Persian empire across the River Halys, thinking, 'I think I'd quite like that empire.' So he asks the Oracle, should he cross the River Halys? And the response is, 'If you cross the river, a mighty empire will fall.'
- 6.23** Croesus, in his hubris, interprets this to mean that the empire that's going to fall is the Persian empire, when in fact, of course, it proved to be his own, the Lydian empire. This is a story quite plausibly historical that Herodotus tells in Book One of his Histories with great relish. This is a, this is a very normal pattern for the Greek mind to discern. Croesus, he overreaches himself. He thinks too much of himself. He didn't see the ambiguity in the Oracle and didn't stick with what he had.

- 6.24** So the Epicurean philosophy of chance and uncertainty is, in a way, continuous with this theology, this theological understanding of our place in the world, even as it repudiates the divine. The Greek mind still needs to accommodate that radical uncertainty. Ancient Greek actually has an entire mood in its grammar called the optative. Would that that would happen? We have the subjunctive, this might happen. They had, well, would that it might happen? There's actually a whole mood that expresses this sense of radical existential uncertainty because the gods might intervene at any time.
- 6.25** Did you know that the Greeks walked backwards through time? What do I mean by that? Well, when we talk about the future, we talk metaphorically as if it's spatially located in front of us. We look ahead to the future. We look into the future. We use the Latin prefix 'pro', prophecy, looking forward. For the Greeks, the word for the future, one word for the future, was connected to the word behind, 'opisthen', behind. Because you can't see what's behind you, just as you can't see into the future. The future is radically shut off to us.
- 6.26** The Greek archaic perfect, 'oida', used to mean, originally meant 'I have seen', came to mean 'I know'. So connected were knowledge and sight, vision, in the Greek, in the Greek mind. That's crystallized into the language, never mind all the fancy philosophy that's working out whether rationalism or empiricism is best. Greek, as it was thought and talked, held fast to this connection between vision and knowledge. And what might happen in the future then was radically unseen. It was something we couldn't have access to. Perhaps one might say it's only within an Abrahamic monotheistic universe that we can pretend to talk about the future reliably at all.
- 6.27** Because, well, that's a universe that is overseen by a benevolent and all-powerful being who yearns for a loving relationship with his creatures, and who has made his broad intentions clear, if not specific intention, his specific intentions. But we look ahead with hope, confidence, in the final just resolution of all things. This is speculative, but that encourages us to turn around and walk forwards through time. There's no such framework within the Greek mind. The gods could strike you down at any time for any reason.
- 6.28** And so there's a kind of emancipating power to Epicurean skepticism about civic religion and Homeric polytheism. But he still can't quite get rid of the element of chance. Still got to reckon with chanciness and with the vicissitudes of human fortune. One political ramification of this is a kind of egalitarianism, or a skepticism towards hierarchy, social and political hierarchies, in society. If you've got a flat metaphysical landscape, where everything is just atomic units, any hierarchically ordered human society is going to seem radically out of conformity with the way the world actually is. And the Epicureans, like the Stoics, thought that the ethical life must consist in an attempt at conformity with the way the world actually is.

- 6.29 And so you can see within Epicurean metaphysics the beginnings of a flat, egalitarian political philosophy. Everybody is made of the same atomic material. In a funny way, it's not so different from the Stoic view that insists that there's this completely, this logos, this principle of intelligibility within us, a ratio, a reason, not just stuff, reason, but everyone has a share in it. Just as we saw that universalizing impulse in the Stoic conception of what it is to be human, we see a similar kind of universalizing egalitarian impulse in the Epicurean conception of human nature, even though it's a radically atomic material chancy one.
- 6.30 The hierarchies that we see, the orders that we project onto the world, are just that, just projections, conventions. It's not the way the world actually is. The way the world actually is, it's just flat. Billiard balls. An endless horizon of billiard balls. You have billiards in America. Pool balls, snooker balls. So on the atomic conception of ultimate reality, there are no real, really existing social gradations. The social order of any era is temporary, it's transient, and it's risen only through chance and necessity, a bit of human free will, and that is what generates the way the world is, the way the world is, and as we find it.
- 6.31 It's curious to note that, in the 19th century, interest in Epicurus was reviving, and there was a figure who would have enormous influence on the 20th century, who wrote his university dissertation on Epicurus' atomism. And that student was none other than Karl Marx. Marx starts his intellectual life with a deep, deep reflection and engagement with, surprisingly, Epicurus' atomism. Now, I don't want to suggest that Epicureanism is what drives, is the philosophy driving Marx in *Das Kapital* and in the *Communist Manifesto*. But you might say that Epicurus makes materialism philosophically plausible for Marx, and it's not inconceivable to conjecture that, it's not inconceivable that Marx understood that it was possible to materialize the world, that the world was to be understood in terms of matter and stuff.
- 6.32 And he's enormously influenced by Hegel, of course, but Hegel makes a lot of room for the world spirit, the *geist*, as the motor of historical change. Marx insists that there is a motor of historical change, but it's not this spooky stuff. It's not *geist*. It's stuff. It's material forces at the atomic level, quite plausibly, and at the economic level, at the social level, at the political level. And because it's purely material, it's determined. There's no room for intention and free agency within this process.
- 6.33 This is, roughly speaking, the atomist view. I mean, there is free will in the sense that the Stoics made room for free will. You could either pull the cart or you could be dragged by the cart. But the cart was going off, whether you like, the cart is going off, whether you like it or not, to the destination that it was always going to. But you can either take it there, freely, or you can hold on to it and try and pull it in a different direction, but you're never going to succeed. You'll just be dragged by it. There's a illusion of freedom, perhaps.

- 6.34 And that becomes a very important way of understanding historical change and the historical process, obviously, the Marxist view of, the Marxist philosophy of history. And it's not obviously false. I mean, I think it is false. And I think that probably the best explanation of why it's false can be found in a wonderful lecture delivered to the London School of Economics by Sir Isaiah Berlin in 1953 on historical inevitability. And Berlin talks brilliantly, writes brilliantly, about how much our language and thought would have to change if we really thought that history was fully determined at all times and in all places.
- 6.35 But one can reject that Epicurean atomist determinism that we see in Marx, or at least maybe we see the fingerprints of in Marx's philosophy of history, and still be impressed by a Marxist analysis of at least some of the sources of historical change. I'm quite impressed, for example, by some contemporary writers who suggest that technology, particularly digital technology, but technology like the pill or the washing machine, has at least a bigger role in terms of historical explanation as books by very clever feminists. We need to make room for material explanation. It's not exciting or sexy very often. Once upon a time, this thing got invented, but look what it could do.
- 6.36 One of the problems with working in academia and living in the world of ideas the whole time is that, well, to a man with a hammer, everything looks like a nail. To a person who lives in the world of ideas, all change must be explained in terms of ideas. Us. Once upon a time, there was a philosopher like me who had thoughts, and they were so important that they changed the course of world history. I think a healthy dose of Epicurean materialism and atomism is a good solvent for that. And recalls us to the sheer messiness of history. And that can be a consolation. When we think times are getting desperate, for example, it's good to be reminded that history is molded by the contingent, the unexpected. History can turn astonishingly quickly in directions that we can never expect.
- 6.37 I think it was the great philosopher footballer Paul Gascoigne in England, who I said, 'I've never made predictions, and I never will.' We are terrible prognosticators as human beings. We are lousy at telling the future. We can't see it coming. Can't see what's ahead. If you're in any doubt about that, read a newspaper from this time last year. And so it's tempting, though, given our astonishing cognitive conquest of virtually everything else, it's deeply frustrating to us that we can't map out the future. And so the, there is something consoling, perhaps, in the thought that we can understand all of the ingredients that will be configured to make up the future. We've got almost everything. And although we can't be quite sure what it's going to be, we know that it's all mapped out. We can turn the futurology into something like a science. That's a kind of something we're drawn to, we find very attractive.
- 6.38 It's often a catastrophic impulse. It is a recipe for, for example, utopianism. This idea that we can refashion society to bring about heaven on Earth. One unfortunate consequence of the collapse of widespread commitment in heaven was not, as it were,

the forgetting of heaven, but the insistence that heaven be brought down to Earth, and that it was achievable in the here and now. 'See you at the barricades, comrade. We're going to bring about a paradise.' And the person who thinks that he's about to bring about a paradise will be able to justify almost any barbarity. So confidence about the future is a common feature of a secular, materialist, atomistic, metaphysic, if you like.

6.39 For the people who believe in the spooky stuff, then, well, you're not going to be so, so worried about the messiness of the waiting room if you think that it's just a waiting room. Society's terrible. We can modify it, we can change it, we can improve it here, we can tinker with it. But human beings are what they are. We're creatures. We're finite. We're fallible. We're fallen. We shouldn't expect perfection. We should expect a lot of people to be wandering around, saying that they can bring about perfection, but they're the people you should really, really watch out for. Let's just do what we can, cope, and not try and wait for paradise, not build it.

6.40 So there is a kind of downstream ramification for politics from your deep understanding of ultimate reality. If you think ultimate reality is stuff plus chance, that is going to have downstream effects on how you understand human worth, how you understand human freedom, how you understand human flourishing in the common good, and how you understand the principles for ordering a just society. There just will be these connections. They're not always going to be exact and precise, but you will see patterns. You will see patterns.

6.41 I think with the rise of corpuscularianism and the rise of materialism and the rise of a programmatic secularism at the end of the 18th century, you just do see the rise of increasingly confident utopian political projects. You do see, just a few months between the cries of the French revolutionaries for equality and fraternity and liberty and the death of all priests, what was it? Diderot's line that he 'would not rest until the neck of the last king was hanging from the guts of the last priest'? That attempt by the French *homme de lumière*, Diderot, d'Holbach, Rousseau, de La Mettrie, this insistence that we are 'homme machine', that we are just mechanistic beings, that the world is just stuff, atoms, matter, nothing else, flat, everything equal. It's a very short step from that to the terror of 1794 and the blood flowing down the streets from the Tuileries, where the guillotines were set up.

6.42 I don't want to make too much of that, and this is, these are lectures on philosophy, not politics, but philosophy is connected to politics. Nothing is really free of philosophy. But politics involves making fundamental normative judgments that presuppose certain, always contestable claims about who we are, what we are, what the world is, how we can understand the world, what the strength of our understanding of the world is, perceptually and cognitively, and how we're fitted for the common life.

6.43 Remember, for Aristotle, we are fitted for community. He advances that biological argument. We're children and we begin as babies. What do we need? Well, if we're a baby, there must have been a mom, there must have been a dad. We need protection.

We need affection. The mother provides affection, the father provides protection, says Aristotle. And so you need a household, an 'oikos'. But an oikos alone in the middle of a forest isn't enough. You need a cluster, and then you need a cluster which becomes a village, and you have a cluster of villages, and that itself needs to be a unit. And then there comes a point where these concentric circles will stop, and you get a 'polis', or I would argue today, a nation.

- 6.44 I'm committed to the nation as being the most extensive, stable unit of moral community, beyond which our loyalties and our affections start to become anemic and theoretical. You might die for your country. You're definitely not going to die for the Trans-Pacific Trade Partnership. That is a theoretical collection of human beings. And so there's a naturalism to Aristotle, which depends upon a very rich underlying understanding of human nature, biology, and justice, and so on, which we don't have with the Epicureans, and we don't have so much with the Stoics. It's almost as if, in turning towards the human, turning towards the self, both the Stoics and the Epicureans lose certain features that seem to be absolutely integral and intrinsic and distinctive of what it is to be human.
- 6.45 Number one, that we are fitted for community and society, that what matters most is not me, but we. Second, that we can't just disown the divine, that we are worshiping beings, or at least beings that are oriented towards something beyond. In fact, Aristotle says in the 10th Book of the Nicomachean Ethics, this is the highest form of human activity. Not inspecting the world and not getting involved in political life, but contemplation, 'theoria'. This is the most godlike of all human activity, where we achieve our perfection, pure understanding, pure exercise of reason. Dolphins don't do that, gerbils don't do that, sunflowers don't do that. It's what makes us us, and it's what puts us in that middle midway point between beast and angel, between world and god. This is the great vision of Pico della Mirandola on his Oration on the Dignity of Man, one of the great manifestos of the Renaissance.
- 6.46 So over the course of the last six lectures, we've gone through a very long cast of fascinating characters, thinking very deep thoughts, generating ideas that can seem strange to us, and some ideas that are even more disturbing for how familiar they are to us. I actually see them in books in the airport. And that's part of the power of ancient philosophy, that it can, well, it can make the familiar strange, and it can make the strange familiar. We look into the past, and when we have that shock of recognition, 'They thought that, too,' or 'They worried about that, too,' you've suddenly got a glimpse into something that's plausibly part of the human condition, that's plausibly true about the human condition.
- 6.47 One thing that's definitely true is that we are inquirers. We look back at these thinkers, and we don't look so much at their answers. We may even laugh at their answers. It's very hard to laugh at their questions. It's very hard to laugh at what troubled them. And that is what ancient philosophy, particularly in the Greek, in its Greek expressions, gives

to us today. That posture of inquiry, of skepticism, of a kind of clarity. It also unsettles us because it makes us realize that a lot of our common assumptions and our common ways of thinking about deep fundamental questions that science can't settle, because they're questions that, by definition, lie beyond the scope of scientific inquiry, are contestable. We've assumed them for so long, and yet it seems that some very bright minds a very long time ago didn't take those assumptions for granted at all.

- 6.48** One obvious example of this would be the primacy of scientific inquiry itself. I think we are intuitively disposed towards treating the sciences as the benchmark of truth and what counts as real. I hope, by the end of these lectures, you will now be in a position to understand how contentious that view is, to understand that Pythagoras and Plato were not idiots when they said, 'Look, surely mathematical truths, surely truths that are true in a transcendent domain, outside space, outside time, not in any kind of causal interaction, and therefore not troubled or disturbed in any way, are truer or are better candidates for what counts as the source and ground of absolute objective truth, truth no matter what, than any truth that science could yield, however clever, however brilliant, however cutting-edge.'
- 6.49** That's a strange assumption. We should come away from Pythagoras and Plato, even if we don't buy their own answers, we should come away from them thinking, 'Well, my assumption that I should start with sense experience and whatever the science tells me is contentious. This is something I have to defend now.' And so on and so on. This is the importance of doing not just philosophy, but the history of philosophy, understanding that ideas have dates, that ideas and arguments are drawn from an ongoing conversation with some of the finest minds that humanity has ever produced.
- 6.50** And unlike science, philosophy, gloriously and frustratingly, does not have any settled answers. That means we can read Plato today and think about Plato today in a way that we are not going to do with Ptolemy or Euclid. These philosophical conversations can't be settled like maths can or like science can. That can be frustrating. It's glorious, though. It's more glorious than it is frustrating, that we can have these conversations at all, because they're conversations about questions that are ultimately deeper than any that could be asked by the mathematician as a mathematician, or by the scientist as a scientist. They're questions about who we are, our place in the world, and the sheer miracle that we can inquire into the world at all, that we can understand the world enough to raise questions about its ultimate meaning.
- 6.51** Aristotle famously said that what sets us apart as animals, sets us apart from anything else in the sublunary realm, that is to say, for him, space-time, everything under the moon, is our desire to understand. Plato's character Socrates, Plato says somewhere that philosophy begins in wonder, 'thaumazein'. Wonder. I hope now, at the end of this series, you have a taste of that wonder, and that you can take it with you in a further philosophical quest for an answer to life's deepest questions. Thanks for listening.
- 6.52** You use the phrase 'all the way down' quite frequently.

- 6.53 Oh, yeah.
- 6.54 And that's a reference to something, isn't it?
- 6.55 Yes, it is. Is it the grandmother who was asked that it's turtles all the way down. So 'all the way down' is a shorthand phrase that covers up a big philosophical dispute between those who think that infinity is possible, an infinity of explanations or an infinity of causes, and those who say that the buck has to stop somewhere; the explanatory buck has to stop somewhere. When I say 'all the way down,' that is ambiguous between all the way down, forever and ever and ever, and if the way down is infinite, then it's all the way down, the infinite chain, and all the way down also if it's finite.
- 6.56 Now, I think that there is a finite chain of explanations, and it's a finite chain of causes, and that it's incoherent to say that there could be an infinity. I think it's incoherent to say that time stretches infinitely far back into the past. Why? Because if the temporal sequence began infinitely far back in the past, then it would take infinitely long for us to be having this conversation now. It would take an infinitely long time for that sequence to reach us having our conversation now. But we are having a conversation now. We're standing at the end of some sequence that could not have begun infinitely far back in the past. So there is a finite temporal sequence stretching all the way back.
- 6.57 Whether it's 14.9 billion years to the Big Bang, or whether there was a bigger bang from which the Big Bang came, and a bigger, bigger bang. I mean, you can have as many Big Bangs as you want, except it has to be a finite number. You have to give a number. It has to be finite. So it's Big Bangs all the way down, or causal sequences all the way down, or temporal intervals, temporal points all the way down in a finite sense.
- 6.58 Isn't it also something about that the Earth is resting on the back of a turtle? And the question is—
- 6.59 Yes, that's right. So the old joke is that, what does the Earth rest on? It's a turtle. Well, what does the turtle rest on? 'Well, it's turtles all the way down,' says the granny. And so this is a, it's like a little parable that emerges from philosophical disputes about the cosmological argument for the existence of God, or I should say, the family of cosmological arguments for the existence of God, which goes something, there are different kinds. The one that's been doing the rounds in recent years is the Kalam cosmological argument that's been given a new lease of life by the Hawking-Penrose singularity theorem. Whatever begins to exist has a cause, premise one. Premise two, the universe began to exist, suggests, claims the Hawking-Penrose singularity theorem. Therefore, the universe has a cause.
- 6.60 What could that cause be? Well, whatever else it is, it can't be in space and time, because that's what the universe is. The universe is space and time. So the cause must be non-spatial and non-temporal. Well, what could that be? Theists, certainly the

Arabic philosophers, many Arabic philosophers, the mutakallim, insisted that this was God. God is a timeless, spaceless originator and cause of the universe. Maybe it's some other kind of being with supreme powers, supreme rationality, but not God. It's a pretty thick slice of God, probably too thick a slice for the atheist's digestive system. But that would be one version.

- 6.61** The advantage of that version is that it doesn't rely, doesn't move too much into questions to do with the infinite. I mean, debates do arise there about the nature of infinity, but perhaps not as forcefully as they do in the Leibnizian version of the cosmological argument, which asks of anything, for any contingent thing, why? What is the explanation for this contingent thing? Any explanation that is given must itself have an explanation, and the explanatory buck is going to move along the chain. And does it go on? The question is, does it go on all the way down? Is it just another turtle explaining every contingent thing?
- 6.62** Well, the person who defends the cosmological argument as an argument for the existence of God, or as a source of all explanation that is not itself in need of explanation, that is self-explaining, will say, 'No, it's not turtles all the way down.' Or rather, if it's turtles all the way down, then at the bottom, it can't just be a turtle because turtles are not self-explanatory. There might not have been turtles, right? That's possible. And if there might not have been turtles, then turtles don't exist no matter what. Like, say, 2 plus 2 equals 4 is a truth, no matter what. So it can't be turtles all the way down. There must be some grand turtle-maker or turtle-explainer who does not depend on anything else for an explanation of his existence. Leibniz says that's God, the ultimate explainer.
- 6.63** Professor Orr, to piggyback on that, Anaxagoras, you mentioned that he believed in being able to split things, and that if you split a piece of gold, I think you mentioned that it would be still gold on either side.
- 6.64** Yes. Homoeomerism. From 'meros', meaning part, and 'homeo', meaning the same. Exactly. So you split the gold, but there's still, as it were, within the parts, the gold, being gold, is shared between the two parts.
- 6.65** But my question would be, where does function come into that? As far as the law of irreducible complexity, with a cell, that you take one part out of a cell and it no longer functions. It no longer is. If you split a cell in half, it's not going to become just two different cells. There's actually a function as to a part of it there.
- 6.66** Yeah, that's a very good question. It's hard to reconstruct, it's hard to speculate how Anaxagoras himself might have answered that. I think the way he would have answered it, or might have answered it, would be to say that the claim about homoeomerism, homoeomerism, is a claim about the fundamental units, as it were, at the deepest fundamental atomic level. And that complexity, certain sufficiently complex systems are simply complex systems in virtue of having different elements configured in

different ways that, as it were, sit above the fundamental units. Might have said something like that.

- 6.67** So a little bit like, think of the atomic as the homoeomeric principle in the contemporary context. So we might say, well, these are two different cells, or this thing loses its function. But an Anaxagorean insight might be, well, yeah, but it's still all atoms. It's still, OK, that thing is without a function, but it's still, the parts that make it up are still, are continuous with this second cell. Now, Aristotle has a very different sort of claim. He would say, absolutely, it becomes a different kind of thing. If you take something's function away, if you take something's form away, it's like taking away the form of Michelangelo's David, and you just have a lump of marble, of course.
- 6.68** And so he's quite suspicious of this idea that this quite Ionian, Milesian idea, that you can explain, that you can offer ultimate explanations in terms of appealing to ultimate material constituents. He thinks that material constituents is just one of the four causes. It's just stuff. It's unformed stuff. And that something only becomes something, it only becomes a substance once it has a form, once it becomes a particular kind of thing, once it has an essence.
- 6.69** So my question is, you mentioned that we saw a resurgence in history of Aristotle in the Renaissance. We saw a resurgence of Epicureanism in the 18th century. And today we're seeing a resurgence of Stoicism. So, philosophically speaking, have we actually added anything to philosophy, or are we just rehashing the same old ideas?
- 6.70** It's a great question. I said at the end of the lecture that philosophy doesn't make progress in the way that science makes progress. And to expect progress of philosophy is in some ways to misunderstand what the philosophical activity is. It's a form of human activity that doesn't have, as it were, a neat resolution. Obviously, you can settle upon a philosophical outlook and defend arguments in support of that outlook. But you're not going to be able to say of your, of rival outlooks, that they are irrational. It's very rare that you'll be able to say that this rival philosophical view is just obviously incoherent or completely contradictory. In that sense, we shouldn't be surprised that different patterns of philosophical thinking from the past come back and fade away again and come back.
- 6.71** But I would say the last 150 years has been something like a golden age, maybe not a golden age, maybe a kind of bronze age in the history of philosophy. There have been some astonishing, astonishing thinkers and astonishing new ideas, both in the Anglo-American tradition and in the continental tradition. I would say of the Anglo-American tradition, and maybe this is my own prejudices coming through, actually not prejudices, I mean judices, judgments, that is to say, I've reached a subtle view here, that the Anglo-American tradition has been hamstrung by, I think, a dogmatic, a priori commitment to naturalism and to the view that all truths are scientific truths, and whatever philosophical outlook you reach must be completely continuous with the

natural sciences. Must, in effect, be explicable in terms of fundamental physics, deep down.

6.72 That may be true. I don't share that view. It may be true. It's not obviously true, and it's not as if the truth, its truth, is buttressed simply by progress in physics. These are two distinct kinds of human inquiry, the scientific and the philosophical. But they've got blended in recent decades or in the last 120 years in a way that I think is unhelpful. And that's why I was suggesting at the end of the lecture that it's important to come away with the strangeness of our assumptions, to be more alert, to use the history of philosophy, particularly the history of ancient philosophy, to unsettle some of our assumptions, particularly the assumption that science fixes the parameters of the real and the true.